

MICHAEL NICHOLSON

**This Imaginary
Feeling of Being
Australian**

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available as
e-book.



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*“In securing the future of the planet,
we secure happiness for ourselves.*

*One of the aims of the Greens is to turn around
the tide of pessimism
amongst the young people of the world.”*

Bob Brown

Chapter One

Conflict and Resolution

Mr. Bob Brown, the President of Australia, sat behind his desk gazing at his laptop.

The surface of his desk was a shiny solar panel he cleaned religiously. It was the first solar panel he had installed on the roof of his house many years earlier. When he updated to better ones, he decided to keep the first one and use it as the top of his desk.

The afternoon sunlight shone onto it and powered all the utilities in his office including the ceiling fan above his head rotating like helicopter rotors. He quietly buffed his solar panel with his elbow.

His office was large and staff members hovered around in shorts and T-shirts. It was another very hot day in Hobart.

“Ah, I see, the link has come up now,” Bob said calmly, as his screen was filled with the crystal-clear images of a reception being held somewhere in Moscow by various oligarchs.

One was addressing a party as waitresses moved around the luxurious room handing out shots of classic Russian vodka and caviar.

“Ladies and gentlemen, I have much pleasure in showing off my most recent desk, filing cabinet and, indeed, the floor,” he said proudly as he grabbed the corner of a table cloth and swept it off, revealing a wooden desk, “made from a three-hundred-year-old tree trunk from the Tarkine rainforest, Tasmania, myrtle in fact!”

The crowded reception gasped and broke into spontaneous applause. “What is its value?” someone called out.

“Over seventy-five million rubles!” he replied proudly, “or fifteen million Australian dollars!”

The glittering chandeliers vibrated as the guests stamped their feet and applauded.

Old growth wood from Tasmania had become one of the most valuable commodities in the world. And like elephant tusks and various ivories from Africa, there was a thriving black market in this wood.

“Well they’re not getting this lot,” Bob said angrily, “not even a toothpick.”

He was referring to the current stand-off in the waters of the Indian Ocean, off the Tarkine National Park, in North West Tasmania.

It had become the focus of world media attention for several weeks now. Three large battleships were anchored in a triangle. They were from the USA, Russia and China.

In the middle was an old merchant ship, of non-descript persuasion, and on its deck sat half a dozen tree trunks, ripped out of the Tarkine rainforest and destined for the black markets of the world.

No one was prepared to claim ownership of the rusted merchant ship carrying the contraband, but there was a suspicion. At any rate, it was surrounded by battleships from the three most powerful superpowers on earth.

The heat was on, and that included another weather extreme, with temperatures well over forty degrees Celsius for three weeks in a row.

Bob glanced over to the corner of his office where the Storyteller was seated tapping away on her laptop.

Her hair was slightly ruffled. She had a tall frame and rimless spectacles and was aged in her fifties. Her name was Marjory, and when her glance met with Bobs, they both nodded in agreement.

“Send in the Collins subs,” Bob announced firmly.

Simultaneously there was a gasp and a “Oh my god,” in three different languages from each of the Commanders of the three battleships.

Anchors immediately began to rise and propellers started to turn. Within minutes, all three battleships were steaming away.

The rusty old merchant ship was alone, drifting aimlessly. But not for long.

Dramatically, six Collins submarines surfaced surrounding the ship. It was an impressive show of naval strength.

“Point your torpedoes at it,” Lieutenant Captain Collins commanded. He then clicked a switch and spoke into a microphone, this time projecting his voice through large speakers.

“Attention! You are to surrender immediately,” he demanded with deafening sound from all six submarines.

There was a momentary pause then sailors strolled out onto the deck of the merchant ship with their hands raised and one of them waving a white handkerchief.

“That’s him again, Vitaliy,” Bob acknowledged, as he recognized the man holding the white flag.

They stood defeated in front of the huge tree trunks lying on the deck.

“Yes! Done,” Bob Brown announced to the staff around him.

They all gazed at the large television screen showing the entire drama unfold live before them.

“And tell Erica to prepare a statement and I will address the media.”

Erica was Bob’s speechwriter. She was a young woman in her thirties, determined, gifted and had a mind of her own.

She was soon tapping in pearls of wisdom on her laptop that were instantly transferred onto the two teleprompters either side of the dais outside.

Shuffling around impatiently were two hundred of the world’s media suffering in the stifling heat. The current heat wave had gone on for three long weeks; however, a severe cool change was on its way.

It was all history now, but an unfortunate confusion in the French translation for the building of fifteen Collins submarines

had regrettably resulted in the Australian government signing up for one hundred and fifty submarines.

No amount of groveling or endless High Court appeals and angry exchanges in the International Court of Justice could undo it.

Every legal avenue was exhausted.

It simply crippled the economy. The country nearly went broke. On the positive side, Australia found itself to be the top naval superpower in the world, eclipsing the United States, China and Russia.

No one would ever forget the ‘Four Corners’ story splashed out by the ABC into the living rooms of nearly every television in Australia.

Monsieur Adelard Voclain was the translator working for the Ministry of Defense. He was a smartly dressed, softly-spoken, middle-aged gentleman with thick glasses.

“At the signing of the contract for the fifteen Collins submarines, why didn’t you notice the extra zero?” the Four Corners reporter inquired.

Voclain shuffled around uncomfortably and averted his eyes.

“Well?” The reporter persisted.

“I forgot my glasses,” Voclain finally replied in a crisp French accent, “I’m sorry.”

With that statement, Adelard Voclain became the most famous public servant in Australian history.

The public was furious.

The power shift in Canberra, the nation’s Capital, was seismic. Most of the politicians of various persuasions were fired, voted out of office, or left the country in disgrace, many living in exile in New Zealand.

Along with the Collins debacle and the ongoing climate mayhem throughout Australia, the resulting snap election was a complete rout.

Antony Green, the psephologist, commentator and election analyst, came out of retirement to make one more election call

after seeing the election polls indicating the biggest landslide in Australian political, and indeed world, history.

Within ten seconds of the Saturday evening election count beginning on television, Antony Green made his call.

“The Greens have formed the Australian government,” Antony announced, as a graph appeared showing all the seats in green, “With virtually no opposition, except for maybe one or two Labor and Liberal politicians, who will sit together, alone, on one side of Parliament,” he concluded.

Adam Bandt was the Prime Minister and a Republic was hurriedly voted in. Bob Brown was elected President, unopposed.

Of the two hundred and twenty-six members of the Australian Parliament, only two were not from the Greens’ party.

Decision-making became simple and swift.

And then another strange phenomenon occurred that transformed the balance of power in Australian politics.

Within a couple of years, the rainforests of Tasmania became a tourist mecca of such magnitude that Tasmania’s economy outgrew the rest of the country.

As many as a million tourists a week flooded into Tasmania, mainly from China, but also from all around the world.

A suburb of Hobart was transformed into a small city of high-rise hotels to accommodate them.

These hotels were something of an architectural gem. Abstract and covered in glass, mirrors and solar panels, glittering like piles of diamonds integrated throughout with green vegetation for ecological sustainability.

Beneath them was an underground railway station where the tourists were whisked along in a very fast train across Tasmania to the Tarkine Rainforest.

Here the tourists could wander through the lush and tranquil rainforests.

There was no logical reason why this tourist boom had taken off. It eclipsed the mining boom that had long ago

receded into history. This tourist boom saved the Australian economy.

The mainland states of Australia were desperate for some of the spoils and would do anything to get the second visitatorial preferences of the tourists.

If Tasmania recommended they visit Sydney or Uluru, for example, on their way home, this state would have an influx of tourists creating major revenue.

The Honorable Adam Bandt, PM, sat in his Canberra office with his staff waiting to see the press conference on the large television.

“Ladies and Gentlemen, the Australian President, Bob Brown,” was the announcement to the two hundred assembled media.

There followed applause, flash bulbs flickering like a fireworks display, and then hushed reverence. The elderly Bob Brown strolled up to the microphone with a help of his trusty walking stick.

“Thank you for your patience,” he said with a smile. He then began reading the speech from the teleprompter.

“As you know, with the help of our fleet of Collins submarines, we have been able to easily resolve the standoff that occurred between Russia, China and the USA in our Tasmanian waters,” he announced calmly, “as I speak, their battleships are on their way home.”

The press conference was beamed to every country in the world and dominated the evening news in most places.

“As the Australian President, I am pleased to say that the crew of the merchant ship, made up of mercenaries from various countries, including, I’m sorry to say, some from mainland Australia, have surrendered.” He looked up at the media.

“This has not saved the three-hundred-year-old Tarkine myrtles that were so cruelly cut down by these loggers and

thieves. I have a good mind to tell my submarine fleet to torpedo the daylights out of merchant ship at the center of this dispute and blow ...”

Bob paused for a moment. He quickly sped-read the next few sentences from the teleprompter to himself, ‘and blow to pieces anyone who doesn’t share my views?’ *I can’t say that*, he thought to himself.

After a pause, he left his teleprompter and made up the rest of his speech by himself.

Within a minute, the temperature dropped thirty degrees and a cold wind swept over the press conference.

“Sorry, and blow me down with a feather, um, this crisis has been resolved. The Australian Greens Party, who are the government of this great nation, will continue to use all naval and military options to neutralize people from anywhere from stealing any old growth trees for the overseas black market,” he resolved firmly.

“As President, I continue to welcome the many tourists we host in Tasmania and, in turn, mainland Australia. Any questions?” he asked.

The assembled world media in front of him tried to protect themselves from the hail storm that suddenly began pelting down on them.

“Australian Associated Press, Mr. President, my Hugo Boss white cloth suit, how do you like it?” a reporter asked.

“Very cool,” Bob assured.

By a quirk of social media, the highest rating reality television show was one playing off the fashions of media reporters against each other in press conferences. Sometimes the reporter didn’t even bother to ask a proper question.

“Sky News, Australia,” a female reporter jumped in, “Do you like my Amani floral dress, Mr. President?”

Bob squinted through the hailstorm and nodded in approval, “Yes, I like that one a lot.”

“And has there been any reaction from the leaders of the US, Russia or China about your use of the Collins submarines to resolve this dispute?” the reporter inquired.

Bob paused for a while. “Not so far. But I’m sure they now understand our way of thinking.”

As the hailstorm intensified from the dark cumulonimbus clouds above, he fended off several more questions about exactly which rainforest his wooden walking stick originated from.

“And in response to your particular line of questioning, I think your non-descript suit is drab,” Bob said as he strolled out of the press conference leaving the reporter looking ashamed.

Hailstones the size of golf balls smashed TV cameras, dented cars, and sent the assembled media scurrying for safety.

Once inside his office, Bob angrily demanded an audience with Erica Collins, his speechwriter of many years.

“What the hell are you writing, Erica?” Bob cursed as Erica sat down opposite him, ‘Blow to pieces anyone who doesn’t share my views?’ Are you mad? Who checked your speech?”

“My father did ... and he liked it,” Erica replied.

Of course he did, Bob thought to himself as his eyes glazed over. A possible naval coup d’état was forever on the table.

Erica’s father was none other than Lieutenant David Collins, the man in charge of the Collins fleet of one hundred and fifty Australian submarines.

The lineage was pure Australian history. Erica’s great, great, great, great, grandfather was David Collins, the founding Lieutenant Governor of the Colony of New South Wales and in 1804 became the founding Lieutenant Governor of the Colony of Van Diemens Land, later to become the state of Tasmania.

Seafaring was in the family blood. They were an extraction of no mere presence.

Even though the Australian President had scrapped the Defense White Paper and replaced it with a Green one, the

country was still stuck with the Oberon-Class Future Submarine Program of one hundred and fifty state-of-the-art submarines.

“You know I like your father,” Bob said to Erica sympathetically, “and I admire your work as my speechwriter,” he continued, as he glanced at the Storyteller seated in the corner of his office, “but The Australian Greens are the government, not the Collins submarine fleet, Erica, do you understand me?”

“Of course I do, Bob. I’ll let you check the next speech before I put it directly onto the teleprompter,” she responded politely.

Chapter Two

Cut to the Chase

A few weeks later, at 3 a.m., a stolen secondhand black AH-64 Apache four-blade helicopter hovered over the remote Tarkine rainforest amidst thick cloud, fog and drizzle.

The conditions were perfect for another heist.

“Out you go,” commanded the pilot with a heavy Russian accent.

Ropes dropped and five balaclava-headed men shimmied down quickly, armed with chainsaws.

The moment they landed, they yanked the cords of their old chainsaws. The sound was deafening.

The base of the three-hundred-year-old myrtle was attacked and cut through from both sides.

“Timber,” whispered Vitaliy, the mercenary in charge.

The giant tree crashed to earth.

Once a great vertical god, now a slain horizontal trunk destined for the black market. Similar to rats mauling a corpse, the five men started cutting off the limb-like branches.

Vitaliy had only escaped Tasmanian police custody the previous week.

In a daring and breath-taking way, he was plucked by helicopter from a high-security courtyard in the refurbished cruciform-shaped Separate Prison at Port Arthur. He was now back in command.

“Scramble! It’s over there!” yelled the Australian military Captain. He urgently scowled the far distance with his powerful night-vision binoculars and located the hovering Apache.

“We should just get there in time, let’s go,” replied one of the ten soldiers as they clambered onto, and kick-started, their motorbikes.

Skidding their way through the dark rainforest, along a narrow pathway, with their headlights beaming through the dense fog, and machine-guns strapped over their backs, time seemed to be on their side.

In daylight hours, these paths were crowded by thousands of tourists wandering through the pristine rainforest. But now, in the dead of night, they were deserted and the chase was on.

With the precision of surgeons, the mercenaries busily stripped the grand myrtle of its branches in a frenzy of fast and furious chainsaw work.

At each end of the long, wide trunk, heavy chains were wrapped around and clamped onto a chain dangling from the Apache hovering above. The chainsaws went silent.

“Hurry. They’re coming,” yelled one of the mercenaries, as he peered into the foggy distance and could see ten headlights bouncing around and approaching fast.

They scrambled onto the huge trunk like mounting a horse. “Up, up, up!” ordered another into his mobile.

Within seconds, the chain went taut and with a jerk the log lifted off the ground of crumpled ferns.

Maneuvering the trunk through the other upright trees was the tricky part. It smashed and bounced its way up with the five mercenaries clinging on tightly.

The ten motorbikes could now be clearly seen from helicopter. It would be a close call.

“Up, up, up! Faster, come on!” they ordered as the trunk broke free of the canopy and the Apache sped off into the night sky.

“Curse it!” the military screamed at each other as they leaped from their motorbikes, “have a shot anyway.”

But there was nothing to shoot.

They could only hear the distant sound of rotors whirling. The helicopter lights were off, the fog was thick, and

the Australian soldiers stood amongst the scattered sawn-off branches, twenty seconds too late.

“They got away,” lamented the patrol leader in disappointment, “I thought we had them.” They wandered around with searchlights on looking for any evidence.

A light flashed from under a thick branch and one soldier reached through and picked it up.

“They dropped a mobile in their haste and it’s ringing,” he said, “hullo? How may I assist you?” the soldier inquired politely.

“What? Who is this?” came the reply in a thick accent. It was Vitaliy.

“Who do you think it is? A cowboy riding a log below your chopper? It’s the Australian military here, you thief. Fly back here right now and surrender ...”

But the line went silent. “He hung up on me. How rude.” The ten soldiers started laughing.

The helicopter was now miles away, swiftly making its way in the dark to the Tasmanian coast.

After about twenty minutes, it was high over the sea and approaching a merchant ship with no apparent lighting.

Soon lights flickered on revealing a helicopter landing pad.

Another tricky maneuver was required to land the log smoothly on the deck without injuring the five mercenaries straddling it.

The pilot was very experienced, paid a fortune, and had fought in various world hot spots for numerous armies, not caring which ones, as long as he made big money.

And there was currently no bigger paycheck than stealing a three-hundred-year-old tree from the Tarkine rainforest.

Nondescript sailors ran around the deck with grappling poles and positioned the long trunk for landing.

It hovered down slowly and steadily and rested on the deck with only a few clinks from the chains as the five mercenaries scrambled off the log and unfastened the chains.

The Apache then landed gracefully on the decks helipad, the rotors stopped swirling, the pilot took off his helmet and climbed out, and all the lights went off.

The engine of the old merchant ship rattled into action and the ships propeller churned around as the boat moved off into the foggy night on a calm sea. The whole mission took less than an hour.

Once out to sea, the chainsaws were noisily back on as they cut up the trunk into smaller pieces to hide and store under the deck.

Chapter Three

The Interior of the Mainland

Bob gazed out the window of his green Presidential jet as it flew over Western Australia. He had just been briefed on the latest logging heist in his beloved Tarkine rainforest.

The merchant ship had vanished without trace, probably by disguise, and the mobile phone the soldier found was traced to a Chinaman of no fixed address in Mongolia.

He could not be located, but they figured this particular tree would end up as a table or floor of a wealthy Chinese family, and financed by the undeclared ‘gray’ income earned by China’s richest businesspeople. It depressed Bob to no end.

His spirits, however, were soon lifted when he sighted the three hundred acres of solar panels below, gleaming and shimmering from the reflected sunlight.

Many years before, Hancock Prospecting had kindly donated the mammoth solar panel installation to the nation.

The output of solar energy was so extensive that it powered all of Timor, Papua New Guinea, Indonesia, their neighboring islands and Australia.

Virtually free electricity for everyone. Except Australia didn’t need much of it because the first law the Greens passed when they swept into office was compulsory solar panels for all buildings everywhere.

The Chairman, Gina Rinehart, now quite elderly but fit and well, had been awarded the Nobel Prize for Renewable Energy, the highest award of its kind in the world. She was a national hero.

“Champagne, Mr. President?” the hostess inquired, handing Bob a glass and filling it with a smile. Whenever he flew over this region of Australia, he celebrated.

No sooner had the three hundred acres of solar panels gone out of sight, the next amazing delight came into view.

It was the largest safari park in the world, second only to the sprawling ones of Kenya's Maasai Mara and Tanzania's Serengeti in Africa.

Bob invited the Storyteller to join him. The airplane cruised to its slowest and lowest allowable height above the safari park. They gazed out the large window revealing the African wildlife below.

With the possible extinction of much of the original wildlife from Africa from ivory and bush meat poachers, modern-life threats and other problems, Australia had built an enormous safari park, some ten thousand acres of it, surrounded by a fence.

It contained breeding hospitals of considerable size, and the rearing and the extensive upbringing of endangered African wildlife was in full swing.

The local indigenous owners of the land were happy to oblige this initiative, enjoying the employment and satisfaction of it all.

Bob and Marjory oohed and aahed at the savanna below them. Amongst the isolated trees and scattered shrubs, they could easily see hippopotamuses, rhinoceros, Kordofan giraffe, Grévy's zebra and, of course, elephants in abundance in this biome.

Originally financed by the Bill and Melinda Gates Foundation, it quickly paid for itself when the millions of tourists that flocked to the Tarkine rainforest were advised to have a second destination visit to this safari park in West Australia on their way home.

Regrettably, about twenty elderly tourists had been mauled to death by lions on one safari park experience.

Once the Greens government scrapped the 'Get on, Get off' busses and replaced them with secure double-deckers, sightseers remained securely inside.

Bob and Marjory reached for their binoculars for a closer inspection and all sorts of African wildlife became apparent.

There was Grant's gazelle, kob, oryx, impala and cheetah, just to name a few, wandering around and lazing in the sun.

"Do you think I should ask Erica to write my speech for our next stop?" Bob asked, as he glanced at the Storyteller, and then resumed peering through his binoculars.

"Well, Bob, you know full well as the Storyteller I consider Erica to be *persona non grata*. Always have, always will," Marjory replied, rubbing the lens of her binoculars on her trousers, and then pointing them down to earth, "Oh my god, look at that, a cheetah and eland in a fight!"

"Hmmm ... I understand your prejudice," Bob pondered aloud, "but Marjory, I must keep her onside. Don't forget, in the subterranean terrains of David Collins' mind, he runs the biggest submarine fleet on earth and wants his daughter to be my speechwriter."

"Be it subterraneously flawed, mind you," Marjory replied, as they simultaneously reached for their glasses of champagne and sipped in unison.

"Last time I flew over this particular area, I spotted no less than a sitatunga, kob and dwarf mongoose, it was such a rare occurrence," Bob mentioned in passing.

Their conversation was interrupted by an announcement from the pilot.

"Sorry to spoil your safari, but we'll be arriving in Safe Haven in twenty minutes."

"Where's Erica?" Bob inquired, putting away his binoculars and standing up. "Ah, there you are," he said, noticing Erica at the back of the plane tapping away on her laptop.

"Erica, would you be good enough to write me a speech for the opening of this new university?" Bob asked politely, "and keep it tame, would you please?"

Erica looked up, “Yes, of course. I’ll give it to you to check this time, Bob,” she replied, and then continued typing.

Bob sat down again and gazed out the window at the birdlife.

“Wow, look at this huge flock of grey crowned-crane around that lake,” he said to Marjory, “they were definitely on the endangered list but are now thriving.”

Chapter Four

The Australian Suburb called Safe Haven

The Presidential jet skidded to a standstill at the Safe Haven International Airport. This Australian suburb was one of the most populous in the country.

The President carefully navigated his way down the steps from his green jet with the help of his walking stick.

A large crowd of well-wishers assembled below him, along with a press contingent. His mobile phone rang and he paused midway down the steps.

“Hello? Ah, hi Adam, I’ve just arrived in Safe Haven. Can I ring you back soon?”

It was the Australian Prime Minister, concerned about a certain issue he wanted to discuss with Bob. *‘Was it about another dedicated refugee television channel Sky News wanted to set up?’* Bob thought to himself.

Already Sky News had five television channels that reported on the suburb of Safe Haven. The population was nearing a quarter of a million people and any reporter, person, or whoever had uninterrupted access to anyone in this sprawling suburb.

After many handshakes, hugs, TV interviews and photo opportunities, Bob finally made it to his most favored form of transport for this visit, a tuk-tuk, with his reliable friend and driver, Mejane.

“Hi Mejane, how are you?” Bob said giving her a long hug. “What a pleasure seeing you again.”

They were soon speeding through the streets of Safe Haven.

It was virtually a self-sufficient suburb with orchards, expansive vegetable gardens, parks, playgrounds, hospitals,

kindergartens, schools, universities, water holes and swimming pools.

There were police stations and offices blocks, where the processing of the various refugees took place.

One end of the suburb opened onto the Indian Ocean. There was a large jetty for refugee arrivals, but since Australia got their huge submarine fleet, refugee arrivals by boat had completely dried up.

There was also an area of the sea that was fenced off so refugees could swim safely without being eaten by sharks.

Many of them, like Mejane, had been swimming there for years. She was originally a teacher from Syria, and so she was teaching in one of the schools.

“How is your visa application going?” Bob inquired as they sped through a large vineyard past a beautifully appointed watering hole crowded with refugees.

“Well it went through a few months ago actually, and I’m free to move to any state in Australia, but I like it here so much I’m staying put,” she explained happily.

“And at least six other teachers I know have made the same decision. And my Egyptian doctor isn’t going anywhere either. The lifestyle here is very comfortable.”

“And your kids, how are they?” Bob asked.

“Oh well the youngest is at kindergarten and the other two at school. My husband has been working full-time on your new university building site, and he says you’ll be pleasantly surprised.”

“Well I’m looking forward to inspecting it and the opening ceremony,” Bob replied. “Oh, and that reminds me, I must ring Adam,” he continued as he tapped on his mobile phone.

“Hello Adam? I’m free to talk now, what was your query?”

Adam Bandt, the Australian Prime Minister, paced nervously around his office in Canberra as he explained the problem to Bob.

“He can’t be serious? When will this happen?” Bob asked incredulously, “tomorrow night on ‘The Book Ends Show’? What the hell does the ABC think it’s up to? Okay, I’ll chat later. Thanks, bye,” Bob said angrily as he put his mobile phone in his pocket.

“What’s happened?” Mejane inquired.

“I can’t believe it, but David Collins is to appear on The Book Ends Show tomorrow evening about his book.”

A cold spray of mist squirted over his face, relieving the extremely high temperature in the mid-forties.

“Erica didn’t even tell me or consult with me,” Bob mumbled as he took out his mobile phone and tapped on favorites.

“Are you at the university yet, Erica? Have you got my speech?” he inquired tersely, “and is there anything else you want to tell me?” he sneered before hanging up.

“Well here we are Bob, your new university,” Mejane announced proudly, as the tuk-tuk sped through the main gate under the new sign, ‘The Bob Brown University of Safe Haven.’

Within seconds, they screeched to a standstill outside the main building where various people mingled with the media and other dignitaries. It was a low-key event but of significant value.

Erica Collins was standing there clutching her finished speech with a sheepish grin.

“Here it is, Bob,” she said as Bob snatched it and buried his head in the text.

“Okay. That’s fine, Erica, put it on the teleprompter.”

Soon the medium-sized hall was full and the new Vice Chancellor, the Lord Mayor of Safe Haven, and the President were seated on the podium.

Speeches followed and Bob tugged on a cord, a small curtain parted, and a brass plaque was revealed announcing the name and date of the opening of this new university.

The whole ceremony was covered live on one of the five dedicated refugee television stations.

Anyone in Australia could watch these stations, but they were particularly popular with the residents of Safe Haven, especially the refugee entertainment channel where many of the refugees, who were singers or dancers, could perform.

This was the third university to be built here. Refugees made good use of these state-of-the-art facilities, and most of the teachers and lecturers were refugees themselves.

After inspecting it, everyone adjourned to the offices upstairs for drinks and Bob asked the Vice Chancellor if he could use his office to talk to Erica. The Storyteller, Marjory, tagged along, and the door was slammed shut.

“Okay Erica, why didn’t you consult me about the appearance on The Book Ends Show tomorrow evening by your father?” Bob asked in an angry tone as he glanced at the Storyteller.

“Oh, I didn’t think I needed to. I thought it was a free world here.”

“Don’t ‘free-world-me,’ Erica. You know perfectly well what I’m talking about. I had to find out from Adam himself. Your father is sailing too close to the wind, again.”

“I’ll be flying home tomorrow and will watch this show with interest,” Bob continued glaring out the window at the new campus. “Now out you go, I’ve got some phone calls to make.”

They left in silence, closing the door behind them, leaving Bob alone as he sat down at the Vice Chancellors desk and took out his mobile phone and tapped on it.

“It’s Brown here, can I speak to Jeremy please?” Bob asked politely, “ah, hello Jeremy, how are you today? Further to our discussion last month, I’ve got an offer for you.”

Chapter Five

The Book Ends Show

Even though visibly distracted, Bob attended a long and enjoyable dinner hosted by the Vice-Chancellor of the new university. A lot of the refugees were highly qualified academics and filling these positions was relatively simple.

The next day, Bob flew back to Tasmania, and then took the very fast train to the Tarkine wilderness where he had a modest holiday house.

As usual, the train was packed with tourists, and from his small balcony overlooking the temperate rainforest, he could clearly see thousands of tourists strolling along the various walking trails. Their money was pouring into the Tasmanian economy.

They couldn't get enough of the 447,000 acres of pristine rainforest, the beautiful blackwood, myrtle and celery topped pines and the thrills of spotting the stars in the abundant habitats like the platypus, echidna, bandicoot, possum and glider and very occasionally the famous Tasmanian Devil.

Bob sat on his balcony by himself, eating his favorite pasta, sipping on a red wine, and pondering the political machinations about to unfold.

He had his holiday house to himself and at 8 p.m. he switched on his television and located his mobile phone and tapped in the number of his official press secretary.

"Hi Mandy, how goes it?" he inquired, putting his feet up on his couch, "you can send out the press release now and make sure you confirm with the ABC that they have received it, okay? Good, thanks, bye."

He dropped his mobile and grabbed the remote control and turned up the sound. The familiar Book Ends Show theme

music played and the beautiful compere, Jennifer, appeared with her bookish smile.

“Well, hello and welcome to another edition of The Book Ends Show, and we have a wonderful guest this evening. Please welcome Lieutenant David Collins, no less, the Commander-in-Chief of our one hundred-and-fifty-odd Collins submarine fleet. What a pleasure it is to have you on our show.”

David Collins nodded, “Thank you for having me.”

With a blank expression, Bob lounged back into his couch as he gazed at his large television.

“Well, we’re here to discuss your new book, David, ‘Subterranean Trouble,’” Jennifer said as she held up the book to reveal the colorful cover shot of a submarine underwater with sharks swimming around it, “I must say, the title rolls of your tongue in a poetic way, doesn’t it?”

“Yes, thank you. It came to me in the shower one day,” Collins replied with a laugh.

“First of all, and clearly a talking point, you chose ‘American Typewriter’ as your font. Why was that?”

“My publisher suggested it, but I liked it a lot because it reminded me of my trusty Olivetti Underwood typewriter I used in my youth, years before the modern computer was even invented,” Collins explained.

Bob quickly flicked around to some other TV stations and soon discovered Sky News was running the show live. ‘*The ABC will be furious about that,*’ he thought to himself.

This was big news and even though The Book Ends Show was the highest rating show on the ABC, it only had a few thousand viewers.

Sky News, on the other hand, commanded a huge audience throughout Australia and was streamed live overseas.

Bob flicked back to the ABC. At the same time, his mobile phone beeped and he read the text from his Chief Press Officer, ‘ABC have confirmed they got the Press Release – cheers Mandy.’

“Did you think you had a book in you, David?” Jennifer asked.

“Well I hope it doesn’t read like an Instructional Manual for driving a submarine ... but yes, I did.”

“So what is this book about?” Jennifer asked, holding it up again for the camera.

“Basically the first half is about my upbringing up to and including my appointment as Commander-in-Chief of the Collins fleet,” he said crossing his arms, “and the second half is loosely about the ambitions I have for the fleet, now that we have one hundred and fifty of them.”

“Yes, well that brings me to the obvious question about your ambitions ...”

At that moment, Jennifer did a double take of the monitor in front of them.

A ‘Breaking News’ announcement began scrolling across the bottom of the screen. They stared at it in silence.

‘*Here we go,*’ Bob thought to himself as he also read it.

‘BREAKING NEWS: The President of Australia has announced in a Press Release that Lieutenant David Collins has been replaced as Commander-in-Chief of the Collins submarine fleet by Lieutenant Jeremy Bligh ...’

After a long and awkward pause, Jennifer blinked her eyes as she looked at Collins, whose expression was somewhat ashen-faced.

“Well this must be a disappointment for you, David,” Jennifer mentioned in a sympathetic tone.

She knew full well that this was the biggest story since the stand-off in the waters off Tasmania between the US, Russia and China, and it was all live on her TV program.

Collins looked stunned, but then another Breaking News story began to scroll across the screen. They went silent again and read it.

‘BREAKING NEWS: The President of Australia, Bob Brown, has announced in a second Press Release that his Chief speechwriter, Erica Collins, has been fired.’

The Storyteller could barely conceal her delight as she glanced at Erica. They were both attending this TV show in the studio audience.

Bob took a gulp of his red and leaned forward to catch what would be said next.

"I guess if there is any silver lining to this it is that your book will become a best seller, David?", Jennifer suggested warmly.

Bob flicked around to the Sky News, which was immediately onto the story.

"What do we know about Lieutenant Jeremy Bligh, the man who is now Commander-in-Chief of Australia's huge Collins submarine fleet?" The Sky anchor asked as a picture flashed up of Jeremy Bligh on the screen.

"First of all, he is a direct descendent of William Bligh, a Vice Admiral in the British navy, who was appointed Governor of New South Wales in 1804. Like William Bligh, Lieutenant Jeremy Bligh is notorious for having an explosive temper," the Sky anchor continued.

"Ten years ago, he was filmed by a mobile phone in a road-rage incident where he used his golf clubs, namely a 5-iron, to smash in the window of a car driven by an old lady who failed to indicate at an intersection." Images of this incident appeared on the screen in a most dramatic way.

"He was arrested and fined and told to serve fifty hours of community service," the newsreader continued.

Bobs mobile rang and he answered it as he watched the breaking news.

"Hello Adam," Bob said as he turned down the TV. "Well the cat is out of the bag now."

"Other than road rage, and a sound recording of him swearing at a goal umpire during a football match," the anchor continued, "Bligh has been a career naval officer for thirty years, plucked out of naval obscurity as the Captain of one of the Collins submarines."

Adam Bandt was in his office in Canberra watching his TV also.

“The press is having a field day on Bligh’s temper, but I think the appointment is a good one, it will blow over ...”

“At least Collins is out of the picture so his ‘ambitions’ can’t be fulfilled. All I need to do now is find a new speech-writer, any ideas?” Bob inquired, as he stared into his glass of red, satisfied with his political moves.

“So you won’t be asking Collins to autograph his book for you?” Adam joked.

At that precise moment, there was a loud crash and the back door was flung open and four people in dark green balaclavas burst in armed with pistols.

One of them fired at the closed-circuit security cameras causing sparks to fly everywhere.

Bob quickly reached for his walking stick and struck the hand of the gunman knocking his pistol to the floor.

“Ouch! What did you do that for?” the gunman cried in self-pity, “it hurt!”

The other gunman snatched the walking stick from Bob and broke it in half.

“You’re coming with us, Mr. President,” he ordered.

“Bob? What’s happening?” Adam called out urgently, since he was still on the phone and could hear the commotion, “Bob, are you alright?”

The four assailants then bundled Bob Brown out the back door and into a car idling outside.

Within seconds, it was speeding down a deserted bush track deep into the Tarkine Rainforest just as the sun set.

Darkness descended on the wild ancient forest.

Chapter Six

The President has been Kidnapped

“Why did you break my walking stick?” Bob calmly inquired, as the car sped along with old growth trees whizzing by lit up by the headlights of the jeep, “it was my favorite.”

“Shut up, Bob, we’re on a mission,” was the impatient reply, “why did you hit my hand with it?”

“I can recognize your voices already ... you’re Jack. I represented you in court about twenty-five years ago, have you forgotten?”

There was a momentary silence.

“Okay, good one, thanks,” Jack replied, putting his arm around Bob’s shoulder.

“But that’s not the point,” a female voice stated.

“Jessica? How are you?” Bob asked.

“Jesus, Bob, when will you stop punishing us with your memory?” Jessica replied, “Don’t worry, you won’t be harmed.”

“I better not be. You’re all in big trouble, you know that. I won’t be able to get you out of jail this time. Law is law,” Bob continued, “take me home, right now.”

With that command, there was muffled laughter in the car. It skidded to a halt.

“Here we are, your home away from home,” Jack said as Bob was bundled out of the car, “Give me a hug.”

Jack clipped a safety hook onto his harness from a dangling cable above and gave it a tug. He put his arms around Bob and pressed a green button. “Hold on.” They started ascending the tall tree.

“I’m a bit old for a tree-sit, Jack,” Bob mentioned as they continued to rise.

They entered a square hole, stopped, shifted sideways, and found themselves in a room, a tree hut actually.

Bob looked around the room.

“Luxurious, a palace,” he said, then gazed out a window into the darkness of the Tarkine canopy.

“We hope you’ll be comfortable here, for the time being,” Jessica said as swept off her green balaclava, revealing a gorgeous face and dreadlocks spilling everywhere.

“Ah, you’re braiding is more ropelike than last time we chatted,” Bob commented as he looked into her eyes, “you ex-greenists are going to cause such mayhem with this silly act. Jessica, rethink it.”

There was a tree trunk in the room. Jessica embraced it and as she did she turned and stared at Bob.

“There is no turning back, you know that, don’t you now?”

Meanwhile, two Australian soldiers wandered through Bob Brown’s holiday shack.

“Hello? Bob, are you here? We just saw the security monitor go blank. Hello? Anyone home?”

They looked down at the broken walking stick and picked up a smashed mobile phone.

Police cars and military jeeps screeched to a stop outside. It was a crime scene.

An army helicopter hovered above beaming a strong spotlight onto the house and surroundings.

A few missent military tweets blasted the news onto television news.

Fox sport was interrupted by the stream and a concerned female anchor, now well into the evening, confronted the audience.

“News we are getting here from CNN suggests that the President of Australia, Mr. Bob Brown, is missing or has been kidnapped,” she announced grimly.

It was bigger news than Harold Holt disappearing into the Portsea Ocean. This time, Bob Brown had disappeared into the Tarkine rainforest.

The Storyteller had a hunch about this and, courtesy of the Prime Minister, she was soon on a hastily arranged military flight jetting to Tasmania.

There was an angry exchange between the Tasmanian police, the Australian military and the Presidents' security officers, who tried in vain to defend themselves.

"Where the hell were you two?" the sergeant yelled at them.

"Brown said he wanted the house to himself and sent us out to feed his pet bandicoots, Sir," one replied nervously.

"Oh great. You know he doesn't have a clue about security," the sergeant thundered, "your orders are not to listen to him."

"But he was adamant, Sir," the security officer pleaded, "and he said he had sighted a spotted-tail Quoll down the trail and wanted us to photograph it for his scrapbook."

The sergeant sat down and rubbed his forehead in despair. He took out a pair of tweezers and carefully lifted Bob's smashed mobile phone and placed it in a plastic bag and sealed it.

"Give this to the forensic unit for fingerprints and any recent calls," he commanded, as he handed it to a policeman. "Oh, and see if there are fingerprints on his busted walking stick."

It was now nearly midnight in the large tree-hut high up in a canopy of the Tarkine. Bob and the four ex-greenists sat around cross-legged on the matted floor.

They were having their dinner after the successful mission and were catching up on their various protests over the past twenty-odd years. Bob was familiar with most of their activities.

Stepladders led to other rooms and everything was well camouflaged. Occasionally the tree hut swayed and creaked if there was some breeze, but it was pretty much a perfectly still evening.

"But Jack, you haven't actually told me what you are demanding," Bob said impatiently.

"I'm getting to that ..."

"I mean how green do you want this country to be?" Bob pleaded calmly, "we're the government, we have a suburb called Safe Haven with about a quarter of a million refugees, we're coal free, the whole of Tasmania is a National Park and a third of mainland Australia, all signed-off in the constitution now, thanks to us, what more do you want?" Bob asked incredulously.

The sound of a helicopter could be heard. Jessica stood up and peered out the small window.

A powerful spotlight beamed over the hut.

"Oh my god, they're quick," she whispered loudly as they all sprang to their feet, "we'd better move now."

Jack hurriedly opened the door to a chute and they bundled Bob into it and gave him a push.

"What the ..." Bob yelled in surprise as he starting whizzing down a wide pipe experiencing the strange sensation of falling.

The outside of it was thoroughly camouflaged so it looked like just another tree trunk.

After only a few seconds, he slid out of the end of it onto a pile of cushions. Right behind him the other four slid out cascading softly into an underground bunker.

In the same room their getaway car was parked. Corridors and tunnels led to other rooms.

A rope dangled out of the helicopter hovering above the tree-hut and a soldier shimmied down onto the roof and climbed in the narrow window with his torch on.

"This one is empty," he said into his lapel microphone, "let's go to the next one," he continued, as he climbed out the window and was pulled up into the helicopter, as it continued on its search.

There were dozens of tree-huts throughout the Tarkine. They had been built up over many years as places of protest against old growth logging.

The forest was by now a hive of activity as military and police crisscrossed the various trails in search of the missing President.

There was an urgency, obviously, because not only would Australia become a laughing stock of the world media, but once daylight broke the forest would be swarming with thousands of tourists again, as it did every day of the year.

After the speedy slide ride, Bob gathered his wits, brushed himself off, stood up, and looked around.

"I must say, what a luxurious bunker you have here," he complimented everyone.

"Yup. The only thing missing is sunlight. We're fifteen feet underground," Jack boasted, "They won't find us here."

He opened another door, "And we have a communications room second to none." He revealed a room full of computers, TV screens and media paraphernalia.

"That reminds me, we must prepare our demands and tweet them out tomorrow."

"Compulsory composting for all households?" Bob inquired with a calm sense of mischief. Everyone glanced at him.

"Oh, it's law already, I forgot we're the government."

"Well we had better get some sleep," Jessica suggested, shrugging her shoulders, "tomorrow will be big."

Bob was shown to his bedroom and the door was locked behind him.

He strolled around the large room in awe. Huge beautiful paintings covered the walls with classical and modern images of the Tarkine.

In the middle of the ceiling hung a green chandelier of glimmering aquamarine, aqua aura and chromium quartz. And there was a beautifully handcrafted wooden table and chair, a sofa and set of wooden drawers.

To one side was a large double bed with a handwoven green quilt resembling moss. A pair of red pajamas, neatly folded and pressed, rested next to the pillows.

The bathroom was even more luxurious. The shower resembled a small waterfall and when Bob turned on the tap warm water cascaded down. It was exactly like Philosopher Falls, one of the gems in the Tarkine.

Piped music quietly played the atmosphere of a temperate rainforest with the sounds of gurgling water, frogs and cello.

Bob went into a deep, comfortable sleep.

Chapter Seven

Urgent Sitting of Parliament

At 9 a.m. the next day, the Australian Parliament was sitting in silence. It was always a surreal scene these days because the Australian Greens filled all the seats except for two.

Adam Bandt, the Prime Minister, sat at the long table with the golden mace on rests at one end.

Opposite him sat the leaders of the Labor and Liberal parties, both with permission from the Speaker of the House to be seated at the table together because they were the only elected members from the Opposition and had combined.

It seemed like only a few years before that the accidental ordering of one hundred and fifty Collins submarines, instead of fifteen, had completely bankrupted the Treasury.

The Greens had been swept into office in the biggest landslide in political history, anywhere. The Labor and Liberal parties were in disgrace, and virtually ceased to exist.

With such an overwhelming majority in both houses, Parliament quickly passed various measures to tackle catastrophic global warming and a smooth transition away from coal towards a clean energy economy along with a raft of other measures.

Australia had become the envy of the world.

On this occasion, however, Parliament was urgently convened to be briefed by the Prime Minister on the unfolding drama coming out of the Tarkine.

"I now call on the Prime Minister to address Parliament," the Speaker announced.

There was hushed anticipation as Prime Minister Bandt stood up and began speaking.

“As you know from the news last night, our Australian President, Bob Brown, has disappeared somewhere in his beloved Tarkine rainforest,” Bandt said, not looking at the two opposition members, but instead addressing the Green Party members who filled all the seats.

“All available resources are being used in the search for him, including the Tasmanian police, the military, ASIO and other law enforcement agencies at our disposal,” he said, without looking at his notes.

“What about your hundred and fifty Collins subs, are you using them?” the Liberal leader quipped. Immediately, loud uproar erupted in the House.

“Order, order!” the Speaker yelled, “would the Member please apologize for that interjection or leave the House now?”

“I apologize,” he conceded quietly.

The house fell silent and the Prime Minister stood up again.

“We don’t have any leads so far. The President was last seen in his modest holiday house in the Tarkine,” he said looking down.

“We also don’t know why there was a lapse of security, but there will be a thorough and far-reaching inquiry into this. In the meantime, we are hoping for the best.” He concluded and sat down.

“Are there any questions without notice?” the Speaker asked.

The leader of the Opposition for the Liberal Party stood up. He paused and looked at the Greens members filling all the seats in the House.

“Can the Prime Minister tell the House why Lieutenant David Collins was suddenly sacked from his position as Commander-in-Chief of the one hundred-and-fifty-odd Collins submarines and replaced by Jeremy Bligh yesterday, and does the disappearance of the President have any connection to this?”

The House went into uproar again with calls of ‘poor taste,’ ‘shame on you’ and other insults. Order was called for and the Prime Minister stood up.

“No idea,” he replied and sat down.

Meanwhile, the President of Australia was fast asleep in his locked room in the bunker deep below the Tarkine.

The four ex-greenists had decided to let him sleep in, after all he was elderly and had been through a lot the previous night, not least having been kidnapped.

Moreover, they were busying themselves in their communications room preparing a tweet, which would contain their demands.

This was a hostage situation of major proportions.

Their demands would be of no small order either, like banning plastic bags nationally, especially since this was made law soon after the Greens became government.

Many other laws had been quickly passed like a total ban on any type of drilling near the Great Barrier Reef, intergenerational equity, subsidies cut for non-renewables, companies taxed properly, especially on off-shore tax havens, and so on.

Jack finished tapping out the short tweet and they re-checked it many times. There was no argument between them since this had been carefully planned and worded for many months in their preparation.

“That’s it,” Jack said proudly. “Now for the issue of timing.”

“Well I think we should wait until lunchtime,” Jessica suggested, as she glanced at one of the televisions, “Now that the extraordinary sitting of Parliament has finished.”

“And I think it would be nice for Bob to watch the announcement unfold with us. I’ll wake him for breakfast.”

Bob awoke from his peaceful slumber with the sound of his door unlocking and opening. Jessica put her head in.

“Rise and shine”, she announced quietly, “We let you sleep in, Bob. Breakfast will be served in ten minutes.”

His eyes blinked open optimistically, but then he scowled when he remembered he had been kidnapped. It wasn’t some strange nightmare, but a real and happening situation.

“Hmmpf. I’ll shower and join you for breakfast then,” he replied rubbing his tired old eyes.

Soon the warm water in his waterfall-like shower was cascading over him and he began to feel cheerier.

He changed into new clothes neatly set out for him and emerged from his room and found the four ex-greenists sitting around the dining table having breakfast.

Another television was on in the background with the Sky News screening images of himself, all being flashed around with jazzy subtitles.

“Cereal?” Jessica asked, as Bob sat down. A cup of tea was poured and he sipped on freshly-squeezed orange juice.

“How did you sleep?” she inquired politely.

“You’re all quite mad,” he interrupted abruptly, “If you’re not shot dead by law enforcement, you’ll certainly get twenty years in jail, and that isn’t swinging on a hammock in a tree hut.”

The mood of the four quickly changed as they glanced at each other.

“Okay Bob, we know what we’re doing,” Jack replied tersely, “So thanks for your advice.”

He gazed into Bob’s eyes. “After breakfast we’re releasing our demands and you can join us in watching it unfold on the news,” Jack said.

“And what are they?” Bob inquired, as he put a spoonful of cereal in his mouth.

Jack took out his mobile phone and showed Bob the tweet. It was all set to go.

*‘We will release the President
unharmd if the Prime Minister
announces the sale of all the
Collins submarines @kidnap#
go/exgreenists #trending.’*

Bob nearly choked on his cereal.

He regained his composure.

Jack pressed send and the tweet was out there.

Adam Bandt was sitting in his office receiving a briefing from various people when his mobile phone beeped and he looked at the tweet.

Both he and Bob simultaneously responded from two different locations in unison.

“Who can afford to buy them?” they asked.

Immediately the tweet was scrolling across the bottom of the television screen on the Sky News. The anchor appeared.

“In breaking news a tweet has been put out by a cell known to the police as ‘ex-greenists,’ who claim they have kidnapped the President of Australia and are demanding that the entire Collins submarine fleet be sold in exchange for him to be released, completely unharmed,” the anchor announced.

He turned to a person on another screen, seated in Canberra, “As an analyst of terrorism and ransom demands, what do you make of this?”

“Well basically this is about the only thing left for the ex-greenists to demand,” the analyst replied, as he juggled with his ear piece.

“All their ideas and beliefs dating back twenty-odd years, when they protested old-growth logging of various forests around Australia, and anything else green-like you can think of, have in fact been made law already by the Greens government,” he replied, folding his arms.

“This chestnut has been on the table for a long time, hasn’t it?” the anchor asked.

“Yes, indeed, and they have a lot of support actually. People simply don’t want Australia to be some sort of naval super-power,” the analyst explained.

“Then again, how can we get rid of them? The North Koreans will obviously make a bid, in their dreams, but their

currency simply isn't strong enough. It would be like giving away trillions of dollars," he concluded.

Adam looked at his chief security advisor. "Well I suggest we put them all on the market in the short term. It might mean they will be satisfied and will release Bob ..."

"At any rate, we certainly can't sell them overnight," the security officer replied in agreement.

They both gazed back at the television, where another person was giving an opinion.

"These ex-greenists are insane people bent on nothing more than chaos and anarchy. They are ego-driven, mad and quite stupid."

In the bunker, the four immediately protested angrily turning to Bob who blinked his eyes in surprise.

"Well that's a nice how-do-you-do, isn't it Bob?" Jack snarled.

Bob quickly feared this type of insult might tip them over the edge.

"Well don't 'The-emperor-has-no-clothes-on' me!" Bob responded, trying to calm the situation. Their eyes sparkled momentarily with his reply and they turned back to the television.

Chapter Eight

Dumplings for Breakfast

The Storyteller checked into one room of the glittering high-rise hotels outside Hobart that accommodated the thousands of tourists that visited Tasmania and drove the tourist boom.

There was a knock on her door. She opened it to find Erica Collins standing there.

“What are you doing here, Erica?” the Storyteller asked, raising her eyebrows, and looking over her rimless glasses with a puzzled expression.

“Same as you, Marjory, I’m going to the Tarkine myself to search for Bob,” she announced, “Even though he sacked me and my father. There is a bigger picture here, I fear ...”

“Okay. Good to see you then. Breakfast?” she asked, as Erica nodded and they strolled towards the lifts.

The silver doors parted revealing a crowded lift of Chinese tourists of various ages.

“Come on, squeeze in,” one said politely.

The doors closed and Erica pressed the 50th floor, the restaurant button, and the lift swiftly ascended.

“Can we join you for breakfast?” one tourist asked, since the Chinese were always keen to converse with Westerners.

Little did they know they were in the presence of the Storyteller and the dismissed Speechmaker to the President.

They did know, however, that the President had been kidnapped, and they were not sure if their visit to the Tarkine would be cancelled.

The lift doors parted revealing a huge crowded restaurant with dozens of round tables and hundreds of tourists eating breakfast.

A waiter immediately approached the Storyteller and Erica and asked where they would like to sit.

“May we have a table on the balcony please?” Erica asked, “Oh, and can some of these tourists join us?”

They all strolled out onto the balcony and sat down and admired the amazing view before them.

On one side were at least twenty tall hotels, each about fifty stories high, covered in glass, mirrors and solar panels, like piles of diamonds glittering in the morning sun.

On the other side, in the distance, was Hobart, the capital of Tasmania, nestled below mountains with a misty still morning overlay.

Once it became apparent that there was a tourist boom of such magnitude, the hotels were quickly built.

The tourists served themselves at a large buffet, but the waiter hovered around the Storyteller and Erica and scribbled down their orders.

Soon everyone was seated with their meals as the lazy Susan rotated with various jams and other breakfast delicacies.

“I was flown here from Sydney by military jet scrambled by the PM last night,” the Storyteller boasted.

“Good for you, Marjory,” Erica replied, rolling her eyes, “I could only get a domestic jet, the price of being persona non grata with Adam.”

“Nonetheless, it was an interesting Book Ends Show,” the Storyteller recalled, “How is your father taking it all?”

“He’s furious. The whole family is, not to mention his staff. They’re now unemployed. The perceived threat of a coup was, of course, total nonsense,” she whispered, after noticing the Chinese tourists seated around the table had gone silent and seemed to be listening in.

“Excuse me, but do you think the Chinese government will buy your submarine fleet?” one elderly tourist piped in

thoughtfully, causing the Storyteller and Erica to go silent and look at him with surprise.

“Sorry?” Erica finally replied.

“The ransom demand to sell your submarine fleet? Someone has to buy them,” the tourist persisted politely.

“Oh, that!” Erica said, pretending not to know, “I guess they might ...” her voice trailed off as she scratched her head.

A tour guide walked over to their table smiling. “I’ve just been told that all visits will go ahead today,” he announced to his group, “So as soon as you’ve finished eating we can take the train.” There was a sigh of relief.

After the enjoyable meal, everyone was in the lift descending swiftly to the station below the hotels with an electric silver train waiting there, which they boarded and sat down.

It whizzed off smoothly. Various monitors lit up giving information about Australia, Tasmania and the Tarkine in particular, in various languages.

The actual train journey, with its speed of 300 kilometers per hour, and the educational devices on the forty-five minute journey, was one of the reasons tourists and school excursions from all around the world flocked to the Tarkine.

The Storyteller and the Speechwriter conversed in hushed tones about their impending search for Bob.

“I researched some of the ex-greenists about ten years ago,” Erica explained to Marjory, “And interviewed one of them, Jack was his name, for a speech Bob had to deliver. He was quite open with me and showed me around his modest tree hut high up in the canopy of the Tarkine.”

They glanced out the window as mountains, rivers, bridges and tunnels shot by.

“But all the tree huts were checked by the military on the first night,” Marjory replied.

“I know, but I’m sure this guy Jack confided with me that they either had a secret chute, or were building one, that led

to some sort of underground bunker,” Erica explained in conspiratorial whispers, “And I know it’s a long shot, but that is where he might be.”

“Do you know where this particular tree is?” Marjory inquired.

“Yes, I found my old mobile phone and it’s still pinpointed on my Google Maps,” Erica proudly whispered as she plugged it into the charger on her arm rest.

She then looked around the packed carriage and waved to a waiter, ordered two mint teas, and they were quickly delivered.

“Don’t you think the police will notice us snooping around?” Marjory wondered aloud as she sipped on her tea. “The area will be swarming with them, and the military ...”

“Hopefully we can get lost amongst the thousands of tourists,” Erica replied, once again gazing out the window as the beautiful scenery sped by.

“But Erica, these are dangerous terrorists, we might get shot,” Marjory warned.

“Well I got fired yesterday, so I have some experience,” Erica quipped.

“We’ll be arriving at the Tarkine railway station in five minutes,” came the announcement over the speakers, “We hope you have enjoyed your journey.”

Soon the electric train was smoothly pulling into a most amazing railway station. It was identical to a dense rainforest. The platform was matted in moss.

Hundreds of tourists alighted and began following various signs to numerous trails.

Others were picked up by jeep-like buses and Erica and Marjory clambered on with their backpacks and sat next to the driver.

“Will you be going near to this area?” Erica asked the driver, as she showed him her mobile phone Google Maps.

“Hmmm, let’s see. About five hundred meters from that particular place,” the driver replied suspiciously, as he looked over at the line of police cars parked near the station.

“I know who you are. You’re the Presidents former speech-writer, I saw you in the studio audience on the Book Ends Show last night.”

“Cover blown already,” the Storyteller lamented, as they both put on their sunglasses and the bus pulled out of the station.

After about half an hour, with a few stops and starts for tourists to get on and off, the bus was deep inside the wild and mysterious Tarkine rainforest.

There were tourists everywhere, wandering along in admiration, at some places five abreast.

“I’ll let you off here,” the driver said as the bus pulled up. “Go down that trail,” he continued pointing in one direction, “Good luck.”

The particular path was virtually deserted. It went up and down, winding left and right, as the Storyteller and Speechmaker began to feel both apprehension and excitement.

Erica looked down at her mobile phone. “Hmm, the tree we are after is right there, I think,” she said quietly as they looked up at it.

“Sure enough, I can see some sort of platform right up there,” Marjory said, as she squinted into a rare ray of sunlight filtering through the canopy.

On a closer inspection of the very wide trunk, they discovered a green cable dangling down and, parting some creeper, they found a small control panel.

“Well this is how we get up there,” Erica said as she tugged on the wire. She took off her small backpack and took out two vests and metal clips.

“It’s lucky I forgot to return these safety vests when I went zip lining at the Pieman River resort a few years back,” Erica boasted.

There were at least twenty zip lining courses scattered around the Tarkine and the nearby rainforest theme parks that had sprung up and were terribly popular. One of the best ways to experience a rainforest was by flying fox.

They clipped the cable to their vests and quickly looked around to make sure no one was following them.

“Here’s goes, cross your fingers and hold me tight,” Erica instructed Marjory as she pressed the green button.

Suddenly they lifted off the ground and were soon ascending the very tall 300-year-old tree. It took a while and further afield they could make out long queues of tourists snaking along amongst the foliage.

Finally, they gracefully passed through the square hole of the platform and the quite small pulley machine stopped. They unclipped the cable and walked inside the tree hut and looked around.

It was empty.

“Now look carefully, we’re after some sort of cupboard or painting that should open and reveal a chute,” Erica explained as they touched and scanned the main room of the tree hut. Erica opened one cupboard door.

“Bingo! This must be it,” she said in excitement as they peered down the long dark narrow tunnel.

Meanwhile, fifty meters below in the bunker, the ex-greenists and Bob Brown were immersed in a philosophical discussion about everything in general, but nothing in particular, as they watched the Sky News.

“By the way, Jack,” Bob asked casually, “Why did this kidnapping thing happen just after I fired Lieutenant Collins?”

“Pure coincidence, Bob,” Jack replied quickly, “We’ve been planning this mission for months.”

“We didn’t even know you had fired him, or your speech-writer for that matter,” Jessica added, “We don’t watch the ABC anyway, too right wing for us,” she concluded.

"I'm disappointed with you, Jack, you've never been on my side, just like at Farmhouse Creek," Bob threw into the conversation wistfully.

"What do you mean by that?" Jack answered defensively.

Bob was referring to the protest at Farmhouse Creek in 1986 when he was assaulted by loggers.

"I jumped onto one their backs and tried to strangle him!"

"Yeah, sure, sure," Bob sneered back sarcastically, "As soon as they waved a chainsaw in your face you scampered off into the forest like a rabbit."

"I was only a teenager. I was sixteen years old, don't forget," Jack protested, "I didn't want to lose my head."

"You didn't want to lose your dirty dreadlocks you mean," Bob kept baiting, "When I was dragged away I saw you kissing your girlfriend."

"That was me, Bob!" Jessica replied angrily, "You know that."

There was a loud commotion, and from the chute in the corner, Erica and the Storyteller came tumbling out onto the cushions like rag dolls.

They looked up to see four pistols pointed at their heads. "Don't shoot!" Bob yelled, "It's Erica and the Storyteller!"

"Put your hands on your heads!" Jack commanded, "Or we'll shoot!"

"Okay, okay," they pleaded as they stood up with their hands on their heads.

"We don't have any guns or knives, we promise," Erica said firmly, "They are banned, don't forget." They exchanged long glances with Bob as they were frisked.

"Give me their mobiles," Jack ordered with his pistol still aimed at them.

Jessica pulled out both of their mobiles phones and quickly turned them off. "They won't be able to trace you now."

"How did you know to find me here?" Bob asked with a bemused expression.

“Wild guess Bob,” Erica replied.

“How brave of you both. Erica, you can have your job back as my chief speechwriter,” Bob announced with his Presidential tone.

“Oh, spare us the hieroglyphics,” Jack said, finally putting down his pistol, “Hello Erica, you remembered visiting me in this tree hut about ten years ago, did you?”

“Yes, I did actually,” Erica replied with a nod.

Then another thing distracted them all on the television and they turned around to look at the screen. It was more breaking news. Bob glanced at the Storyteller.

“We have been receiving news that fifty of the Collins submarines have started leaving their port in Darwin,” the anchor announced.

Everyone in the bunker went silent as they gazed at the TV screen. Soon Adam Bandt appeared on the screen surrounded by reporters.

“I have nothing to do with this,” Bandt replied tersely to them, “Only the President has the power to use them. It’s in the constitution, don’t forget.”

“Well I didn’t tell them to set sail, I’m being held hostage here in a bunker,” Bob calmly replied to the TV screen as if he was conducting a one-on-one conversation with his Prime Minister. Everyone glanced slyly at Bob.

“Well who can tell them what to do then?” a reporter asked loudly, pointing her microphone in a menacing way at Bandt.

“The new Commander-in-Chief is Jeremy Bligh and he is in Darwin, I believe,” Bandt replied coldly, “And the President is missing, out of communication, don’t forget.”

Chapter Nine

Bligh's Revenge

Lieutenant Bligh stood proudly at the command post in his submarine, surrounded by sophisticated navigational equipment, with officers coming and going.

Half the hundred-and-fifty-odd fleet had been docked in Darwin Harbor and the rest were scattered around Australia.

“Full steam ahead,” he ordered into his microphone connected to the Captains of the other forty-nine Collins submarines, as they moved in formation out of the Darwin Harbor.

It was only the day before that Bligh had been appointed Commander-in-Chief of the huge fleet replacing Collins.

Bligh knew full well that the President had been kidnapped and therefore Bligh was in command and he wasted no time ordering fifty of the fleet into action.

“Nice day for it,” his second-in-command chimed in. Like most of the crew members, he was pleased to be in action.

For far too long, most of the fleet had remained stationary in the various docks around Australia.

“No time for idle chatter, have you sent off the email to 10 Downing Street?” Bligh asked tersely.

Another crewman with headphones on looked around from his computer, “Yes Sir, sent,” he replied, giving a thumbs up.

“Okay, fill the ballast tanks, we’re going under, and go to radio silence,” Bligh ordered confidently, “We don’t want some annoying phone call from the Prime Minister,” he pondered loudly.

Lieutenant Jeremy Bligh was an experienced submarine captain coming from impressive ancestry, being a direct descendant of Rear Admiral William Bligh.

He was proud that William had sailed with Captain James Cook, no less, and was part of an inner circle of friends with the likes of Charles Darwin and Joseph Banks.

He also knew of the way William Bligh had been treated after the famous ‘Mutiny on the Bounty,’ when rogue sailors on his ship mutinied and set him adrift in a small craft with a handful of loyal crew. They had survived, but on returning to England his reputation had been blackened.

It was family pride at stake and now Lieutenant Jeremy Bligh had the opportunity to restore it.

Meanwhile, in Canberra, the Prime Minister was getting yet another briefing as he buried his head in his hands, “How much worse can this get?” he said aloud.

“A lot, I’m afraid to tell you,” his naval advisor lamented, “Bligh has put the entire fleet into radio silence, now we can’t even track them.”

“You sure there is no global positioning system we can use?” the Prime Minister asked hopefully.

“Nope, sorry. These subs have the latest electronics in them. They are built for endurance and stealth, second to none,” he replied, “That’s why they cost so much.”

“Well, what do you think?” Adam asked.

The naval advisor walked over to a large map of the world and picked up a pointer.

“Well they’re definitely heading towards Timor,” he announced, as he tapped on the Timor Sea, “But after that they could go anywhere, they could split up in all directions. God only knows.”

“Maybe Bligh has just taken them out on a simple naval exercise,” Bandt suggested optimistically, “It may be as innocent as that?”

“I doubt it. He’s got fifty subs with him and has gone into radio silence, so it would seem he has got something to hide,” the advisor suggested, as the rest of the staff in the Prime Minister’s office looked on glumly.

The mood was no less merry in the bunker as they sat and watched the television news.

“Well how do you feel now, Jack?” Bob asked earnestly, as he wagged his finger at him, “You go and kidnap me, demanding that the entire Collins submarines be sold as your ransom demand, then we find Bligh has absconded with a third of them.”

“Well, we don’t know where or what he is doing, yet,” Jack replied defensively.

“Yeah, but I’m the only one who can over-rule him, Jack,” Bob threatened, “So by you keeping me hostage it appears you are now allowing Bligh to use the fleet for his own naval ambitions, which is exactly what you are against, yes?”

“Well we’re not releasing you, so get used to it,” Jack replied angrily, “It’s early days now.”

Bob glanced at the Storyteller and then his Speechwriter.

They all shared the same conclusion in their minds. They were being held hostage by people they knew all too well, and these people were stubborn, very stubborn.

Also watching everything unfold on the TV news was Lieutenant David Collins himself, in full naval uniform.

He was sitting on the sofa in his luxurious Sydney mansion overlooking a secluded part of Middle Harbor, and with his own private jetty.

Parked at the jetty was his Collins submarine. No one had thought to take it from him, even though he had been dismissed.

Members of his crew had started arriving at the jetty and he strolled down to meet them.

“Thank you for having confidence in me,” he announced to them all, as they assembled in front of him.

“Well I for one have no time for Bligh,” the subs second-in-command agreed loudly, “He’s got too much baggage going back generations. And an explosive temper. You’ve got our full support, David.”

“And I’ve still got the keys to this thing,” Collins said as he jangled them in the air, “So let’s go after him!”

The crew applauded enthusiastically as they clambered onto the submarine docked there.

After all, they had nothing to lose since they were his loyal crew and they had all lost their jobs when Collins was sacked. Everyone knew Bligh was up to no good.

Soon the last of them had climbed inside and the hatch was slammed shut. Collins pushed the key into the ignition and twisted it. Immediately the control panel lit up and the hum of machinery began.

“Okay, all systems go,” Collins ordered, and the huge submarine was soon making its way under Sydney Harbor.

In all the excitement, David Collins had completely forgotten that he had agreed to an exclusive interview with Sky News about his abrupt dismissal and a chance to promote his book.

As his submarine cast off from his private jetty, the Sky News crew was standing amongst the gum trees surrounding his mansion filming the whole thing.

“And so we bade farewell to David Collins and his submarine as he powers off to the Heads in pursuit of Bligh,” the reporter concluded.

This live-cross went onto the Sky News as another breaking story that was captivating the nation and, indeed, the world.

Chapter Ten

The Merchant Ship

As the sun set over the Timor Sea, a merchant ship chugged along on the calm sea.

The captain was delighted, as they were now out of Australian waters, and they had their contraband of a three-hundred-year-old myrtle stored safely under the deck. It was worth a fortune on the black market.

“I think we deserve a stiff vodka, comrades!” Vitaliy, the captain, announced to his motley crew of various nationalities, as glasses were filled.

“You did well dear Vitaliy,” one of the crew complimented, “It was touch and go there for a while on the Tarkine coast, but you navigated this old ship good!”

“And may I thank you all,” the captain replied merrily as he gulped down a large glass of his favorite vodka and chomped on a pretzel, “We’ll all be filthy rich in a matter of weeks when we off-load our tree to the dealer ... nightlife, here we come!” he yelled.

Suddenly there was a loud clunking sound, and they all fell over from the mysterious impact.

After standing up in a confused state, the captain looked out of a porthole but couldn’t see anything at all.

“Was it a whale?” one sailor asked.

“What is the damage?” another urgently said, before they all went silent and stared in awe.

A huge modern Collins submarine surfaced out of the depths of the Timor Sea. It totally eclipsed the rusty old merchant vessel and was silhouetted by the red sunset sinking behind it.

Equally surprised was Lieutenant Bligh. He gazed intently through the periscope at the slightly damaged merchant ship.

“How the hell did we ram that?” he demanded to know angrily, “I thought our radar could see anything!”

“Probably some faulty wiring, Sir,” a crewman replied, tapping on the radar screen.

“We’ve hit a ship,” Bligh announced to the rest of the fleet, “Stop and surface while we sort it out.”

The sailors on the merchant ship, slightly drunk, couldn’t quite believe their eyes as forty-nine additional submarines surfaced around them.

“Looks like we’re outnumbered men,” Vitaliy announced, feeling sorry for himself.

Within minutes, the sub was alongside and Bligh’s crew were swarming above and below the deck of the old merchant ship.

Once the Tarkine wood was discovered, they were put in handcuffs.

“My name is Lieutenant Bligh, and you’re all under arrest,” Bligh announced to the disparate bunch of sailors from the merchant ship, “For the serious crime of stealing an old growth tree from the Tarkine rainforest,” Bligh continued, “And you can expect a long time in jail.”

“What if we apologize?” Vitaliy asked.

“Transfer them onto my submarine and guard them,” Bligh ordered, as he looked at one of his crew whose name was Fletcher Smith.

The sailors were pushed and shoved into the submarine and herded into a small room and told to sit down.

Fletcher Smith sat down with them holding his machine gun.

Vitaliy dissolutely looked at him. He had read various diaries, badly translated books from English into Russian, about the British naval explorers around the 1800s and vaguely recognized the name Bligh.

“Excuse me sir, is the Captain of this submarine related to William Bligh?” Vitaliy asked Fletcher, who momentarily flinched.

“Yes, a direct descendant,” he replied, looking away curtly.

The Russian captain was a wryly experienced old man who knew how to deal with any sailors, Australian or otherwise.

He lent forward and spoke quietly to Fletcher.

“Do you know the tree trunk we have is worth about thirty million dollars?” Vitaliy asked, breathing vodka onto Fletcher’s face.

“If some of you commandeered this submarine, we could be out of here in no time,” he suggested softly, “We could meet our connection and collect the money and get away scot free.”

He continued with his eyes twinkling, “Who’s going to take on a Collins submarine, or even find it for that matter?”

He sat back and waited for the idea to plant. Fletcher remained silent, deep in thought.

After awhile, Fletcher left the room to have a break and chatted in conspiratorial tones to some of his crewmates.

Meanwhile Lieutenant Bligh was sitting in his cabin writing out a report on finding the merchant ship and the old growth tree trunk on board. With the subsequent arrests, it would be a feather in his cap, he thought to himself.

There was a knock at his door.

He stood up and opened it to find Fletcher and a few other crew members standing there with their machine guns pointed at him.

‘I knew signing up a sailor called Fletcher was a lousy idea,’ Bligh sighed to himself.

“We are taking over this submarine,” Fletcher announced, “This is a mutiny.”

In no time at all, Bligh and any of his supporters were bundled out of the submarine and unceremoniously dumped on the old merchant ship.

Meanwhile Fletcher and his supporters along with the mercenaries loaded the wood into the submarine, filling a lot of the cabins.

It was under the dark of night and all the other submarines were none the wiser.

Bligh was furious, but there was nothing he could do. Fletcher then sent a text to the other submarines informing them that the crash had been sorted and the journey was to continue.

All the submarines submerged and it was full steam ahead.

Bligh and his supporters stormed up to the bridge of the merchant ship to send out an SOS, but all the wires had been ripped out and most of the old rusty engine had been thrown overboard.

After thoroughly searching the ship, Bligh's crew could only find crates of vodka and packets of pretzels.

"Damn it all!" Bligh fumed, "We'll just have to sit it out until someone finds us."

The old merchant ship floated aimlessly on the Timor sea.

Chapter Eleven

All is Not What it Seems

Steaming up the east coast of Australia was David Collins and his loyal crew, completely unaware of anything that had transpired, and clearly enjoying themselves.

So much so that they had surfaced and had one of the crew waterskiing behind the huge submarine. On the deck, a barbecue sizzled away and other crew members lazed around in deck chairs enjoying the sunny weather.

The captain, David Collins, had switched on radio silence overnight, but now that they had surfaced and were making great progress, he decided to switch on his global positioning system.

Sky News immediately dispatched a helicopter to go after them, and soon the submarine had been located and was beamed live to the news.

The Australian Prime Minister was alerted and turned on his television.

“Can we get him on the phone?” Bandt asked his naval advisor, who began dialing some numbers, and handed him a mobile phone, “Thanks ... ah good, it’s ringing.”

The phone started beeping next to David Collins in the control room of the submarine.

“Hello?” Collins answered coolly.

“Hello David, it’s Adam here,” he said equally coolly, since they both knew each other well, “Is it okay to talk?”

“Yes, of course,” Collins replied.

He knew full well what he was doing was illegal, but then again, someone had to go after Bligh, even though no one was aware of the mutiny on the Timor Sea.

"How is your barbecue going up on deck?" he asked watching the water-skier crisscrossing the waves from the wake of the submarine live on television.

"Good thanks, Adam," he replied, "The crew are mixing some R & R with their mission."

"And, um, what would that mission be?" Bandt inquired.

"To catch Bligh and arrest him," Collins explained, "I realize I have no power anymore, but I can make a citizen's arrest, didn't you know?"

"You think you'll be able to match fifty submarines?" Adam probed carefully.

There was silence at the other end. After a long pause, Collins replied.

"Well someone has to do something and that someone is me, good day, Adam," Collins muttered then hung up.

"Thank you for your kind gesture," Bandt replied as he heard the dial tone, "Hmm, wouldn't you know it?" he said to his naval advisor.

"Well we can't really stop him," the advisor continued, "He's got one of our best submarines and, apparently, a loyal crew ... enjoying themselves too," he concluded as they watched the TV and saw some of the crew turning over the sausages on the barbecue.

Meanwhile, on the old rusty merchant ship, floating alone on the Timor Sea, Bligh and his supporters were making a closer inspection of the rooms under the deck.

They had discovered one door that was padlocked.

"What's this?" Bligh asked when he was called downstairs.

"Well we think there is some sort of large room here behind this door, but it's locked," a member of his crew explained.

Another crew member had found an old petrol-driven jackhammer, of all things, amongst a pile of chain saws, and yanked on the cord and it loudly rumbled into action.

Within seconds, the padlock was drilled into pieces and the door creaked open to reveal an Apache helicopter sitting there.

“Oh my god!” Bligh said in surprise, “Our flying life raft!”

A few members of the crew raced into the room and peered into the cockpit.

“The keys are in the ignition!” one crew member said excitedly, “And I know how to fly these things,” he continued proudly, having served in both the Australian air force and navy.

Another crew member located a long chain and started pulling it. Slowly, the roof began to open with sunlight streaming in.

“Okay, let’s climb on board and see if we can reach Darwin,” Bligh ordered, as everyone clambered on.

The pilot turned the key and everything lit up and the rotors started twirling. The noise was deafening.

“Here goes,” the pilot announced as the helicopter lifted off and emerged out of the deck of the merchant ship, “So far so good, and there’s plenty of fuel in the tank.”

He tapped on the compass and pointed the helicopter to the south and away they flew.

“Once we get to Darwin, I can return to my office and take charge of the fleet,” Bligh planned aloud, “Oh, does this old thing have a radio?”

The pilot searched the control panel and switched it on. It was the ABC National News crackling over the tiny speakers.

“... and this is the most amazing news to come out of the United Kingdom since the outbreak of World War Two ...” came the announcement, as Bligh tried to turn up the volume.

“What is?” Bligh asked urgently, as he fiddled with the volume knob.

“Do you think it’s about that email I sent for you to 10 Downing Street announcing your plans to invade Great Britain?” the pilot asked.

“Curse it,” Bligh said angrily, as the knob broke off and the radio went silent.

The helicopter continued to speed back to Darwin.

The Prime Minister stood gob-smacked, as he watched the latest breaking news on the TV. This one completely eclipsed any other breaking news that had ever broken for over seventy years.

In the bunker, deep below the Tarkine, Bob Brown was incredulous.

"I can't believe this!" he said, staring intently at the Storyteller.

The ex-greenists stood alongside him openmouthed.

The Sky News anchor continued, "... and to repeat the breaking news, after an urgently convened sitting of the British Parliament, the British Prime Minister has put out a short Press Release, which says: 'Under the circumstances of Lieutenant Bligh commanding a fleet of fifty Collins submarines steaming towards the United Kingdom,'" the anchor announced, as he wiped some sweat from his brow.

"The British Parliament has unanimously agreed to hand over control of the country to the Australian President as an interim measure to keep peace."

"This means I can issue them with a list of new green laws," Bob said enthusiastically, "What do you think now of your demands, Jack?" Bob asked, scowling at him.

"Hmmpf," Jack replied defiantly, "Maybe we can water down our demands to selling only half the fleet," he concurred.

"We will now interrupt this breaking news to cross live to Buckingham Palace as King William is about to address his country," the anchor announced excitedly.

There was a hive of activity in the Prime Minister's office in Canberra. Everyone was transfixed.

The screen was filled by images of Buckingham Palace with dramatic music. It was under ten meters of snow and there was extreme dense fog.

The hundreds of world media assembled outside on sleds couldn't see a thing. Climate change was at its worst.

King William appeared on the screen seated calmly in his office. He was dressed in full military uniform.

“It is with great interest that I had an audience with our Prime Minister, and agreed with his request to hand over power of our government to the Australian President, Mr. Bob Brown, a gentleman our family has always admired,” he continued serenely.

“As you know, Australia has become a role model for the entire world with all the green measures they have put in place and enshrined in their Constitution ...”

There was commotion outside Adam Bandts’ office.

The Italian ambassador burst into the room waving some papers. Everyone looked at him with surprise.

“Mr. Prime Minister, I must have an urgent meeting with you,” he said breathlessly.

“For what reason?” a visibly confused Bandt replied.

He was still, after all, absorbing the news of England effectively surrendering to Australia.

“I have a communique from the Italian Prime Minister requesting that your government runs Italy,” the ambassador blurted out as he glanced excitedly at the TV screen.

King William, slightly balding, continued his speech.

“In many ways, this decision by my government, is a case of ‘reverse colonization,’ and we welcome it,” the King of England continued warmly.

The switchboard of Adam Bandts’ phone was lighting up. His secretary glanced at it and whispered to Adam.

“Prime Minister, you have incoming calls waiting for you to answer from Finland, Poland, Spain, Indonesia, Africa ...”

Everyone in the bunker continued to watch the address by King William.

Astonishment bordered on incredulity when they read the Breaking News scrolling along the bottom of the screen.

‘Breaking News: Leaders from countries such as France, Jamaica, Israel, Holland and Belgium have invited the President of Australia to control their governments ...’

“Wow!” Bob said, turning to the Storyteller, “That seems a lot of work for me.”

“These countries are toppling over like dominoes,” Marjory replied aghast.

“But how can I do this if I’m being held captive?” he asked angrily.

“Jack? Where are you?” he asked searching the room.

All four ex-greenists had adjourned to their communications room to send out a tweet changing their ransom demand.

“You see Jack?” Bob said as he stormed into their room, “Most of Europe wants to adopt my Green measures; surely this is what you must want?”

Jack looked up as they argued about what tweet they should send out.

“The government will say we’re backing down if we demand they sell only half of the subs in exchange for releasing Bob,” Jessica pleaded with Jack.

“Your cup of tea is ready, Bob,” Erica called out from the other room.

“I didn’t ask for a cup of tea,” Bob answered quickly, as he focused on the tweet the ex-greenists were composing.

“Bob! You did, come and get your cup of tea,” Erica kept pleading.

Bob looked around and noticed her making faces and motioning urgently.

“Oh, okay, coming,” Bob said as he strolled out of one room into another.

Erica slammed shut the door into the communications room and quickly locked it.

“Aha! Trapped them!” Erica announced proudly as the Storyteller laughed.

“What?” Bob asked.

“I noticed the door has a lock. I’ve locked it. They can’t get out,” she continued as they walked over to the jeep that was stationed there next to a few motorbikes, “The keys are in the ignition, we can escape!”

With excited haste, they clambered into the jeep. It was almost tank-like. They could hear the ex-greenists banging on the door with angry but muffled demands, “Let us out!”

Erica was in the driver’s seat. “Hold on!” she warned, as she turned the key and the engine started.

With that she clunked the gear stick into forward and slammed her foot on the accelerator. The thick wheels spun into force and the jeep raced up the ramp.

“Cover your heads,” Erica ordered, as it smashed through the camouflaged horizontal roller door, sending metal, wood and ferns flying everywhere.

They emerged from the bunker, skidding around a trail, and bathed in sunlight filtering through the canopy above.

Soon they were speeding along a narrow road before reaching an intersection.

“Turn left here,” Bob ordered.

He knew the Tarkine trails and roads like the veins in the back of his hand. But it was a mistake.

In front of them was a huge crowd of tourists wandering along. Maybe two hundred of them, five deep, blocking the road completely.

“I’ll go off road and bypass them,” Erica suggested.

“Oh no you won’t!” Bob ordered like a Presidential decree, “Toot your horn!”

Erica started pressing the horn loudly. The tourists looked around and quickly parted, creating an easy way through and the jeep sped between them.

In the communications room of the bunker, the ex-greenists were screaming at each other.

“Just shoot the lock!” Jessica yelled.

“What about our tweet?” Jack screamed back.

“Oh my god, send the tweet and shoot the lock at the same time!” Jessica demanded as Jack simultaneously pressed send on his tweet and used his pistol to shoot the door lock to pieces.

It drifted open in a haze of smoke. They rushed through into the now vacant room of the bunker.

Scrambling onto their motorbikes, kick-starting them in unison, they roared up the ramp in hot pursuit.

Erica was a good driver. The jeep skidded around corners as Bob gave directions.

Sometimes they would come across hundreds of tourists again and had to slow down completely, honking the horn loudly, then speeding off again.

The plan was to get to the Tarkine railway station, where there would be a lot of military, and they would be safe. But they feared the ex-greenists would recapture them before they got there.

They could hear a police siren wailing.

“A police car!” Erica said, glancing into the rear vision mirror, “What a stroke of luck,” she said in relief as she pulled over.

The policeman walked over to the driver’s window.

“You were speeding. The speed limit is 30 kph,” the policeman said, as he scribbled out a speeding ticket, “I clocked you at 31 kph.”

“No, no, no!” Erica protested, “This is Bob Brown!” The policeman gazed into the window, then resumed writing the ticket.

“I’m the President of Australia!” Bob said urgently in disbelief, “I’ve just escaped from being kidnapped!”

“That will be a \$ 547 fine and twenty hours of community service,” the policeman announced, as he handed Erica the ticket, “Now be on your way.”

“Are you mad?” Erica replied.

“Right. That’s showing disrespect to a police officer,” he said as he scribbled out another ticket, “You’ve violated the Greens Manual for Manners, so that’s another twenty hours of community service. So be on your way now.”

Erica sped off at 30 kph until they were out of sight of the police car, and then speeded up.

“I can’t believe that,” Erica said as they skidded around another corner.

“The \$ 547 fine?” Bob inquired.

“No, the twenty hours of community service,” Erica replied shaking her head.

One of the pieces of legislation the Greens had passed was adding community service orders on top of speeding fines.

“Well it’s worked well right across the country,” Bob argued, “It means we have a huge labor force available for community services.”

“And the Greens Manual for Manners was one of your best initiatives, Bob,” the Storyteller complimented, “And it’s been a worldwide bestseller!”

“There has been a noticeable improvement in general friendliness, courtesy and manners across the country since you issued this manual,” the Storyteller continued.

“What’s wrong?” Bob asked Erica as she tapped her knuckle on the electricity gage.

“I think we’re about to run out of power,” Erica replied, “They forgot to recharge the batteries.”

“Well there’s a recharging station about ten minutes away, turn left here,” Bob instructed, “I hope we can make it.”

Bob’s sense of direction and navigational skills were excellent.

The jeeps power cut out just meters before they reached a group of huts, and they rolled up next to the recharging posts and stopped.

Erica leaped out and plugged in the cord and the battery light lit up.

"This will take about five minutes, what do you suggest we do?" Bob asked, as he glanced at the Storyteller in the back seat.

"Well there's a café here, we may as well get a cup of coffee," she suggested, as they all got out and strolled into the nearby souvenir shop.

Immediately Bob was mobbed by Chinese tourists wanting his autograph. They sat down at a table and a waiter approached.

"Aren't you Bob Brown?" the waiter inquired, "What are you doing here?"

There was a small TV in the corner, and they all looked over at it.

"We just escaped, and are trying to get to the Tarkine railway station," Bob explained as they watched the blanket coverage of all the amazing news that was unfolding, "But we fear our kidnappers will catch up, they're on motorbikes."

A whole lot of tourists and students listened in and started talking amongst themselves. Word soon spread to the hundreds of tourists hiking past.

There was a roar of motorbike engines approaching.

"That's them, quick let's go!" Bob said as he glanced out the window and then at the Storyteller.

The three of them scrambled into the jeep after Erica unplugged the charger and she planted her foot and the jeep sped off.

Bob and the Storyteller turned around and looked out the rear window. It was an amazing scene of mayhem.

Hundreds of Chinese tourists crowded around the four ex-greenists blocking their way.

They pulled them off their motorbikes and wrestled them to the ground. They disarmed them and took their keys. And they tied them to a tree trunk until the police arrived. Jack was furious.

"Remind me to find out where those tourists are from," Bob instructed Erica, as she skidded around another corner, "They should all be awarded the Green medal."

After about ten minutes, the Tarkine railway station came into view. The military and police were swarming everywhere. The jeep skidded to a standstill.

“We were expecting you, Mr. President,” a senior military figure announced as he opened the door and gave a crisp salute, “We’ve had many calls from the souvenir shop and various tourists.”

Bob stepped out followed by his Speechwriter and the Storyteller. Everyone milled around and cheered.

“We’ve reserved a carriage for you,” the military figure explained, as they hurriedly entered the station and boarded the gleaming electric train waiting there.

Immediately it pulled out of the station and was soon speeding along at 300 kilometers an hour.

Bob gave a sigh of relief as he glanced at Erica and the Storyteller. Tea and sandwiches were served as the beautiful scenery whizzed by.

A few Royal Australian Air Force hornets flew above the very fast train as cover.

An assistant handed Bob a mobile phone, “It’s Adam on the phone, Mr. President.”

“Hello Adam, how are you?” Bob inquired calmly.

“I’m so glad your safe,” Bandt said from the Prime Minister’s office in Canberra, “But we are not out of the woods by a long shot,” Adam cautioned.

“Well as soon as I get to my office in Hobart, I’ll dismiss Bligh, of course, and turn around the fifty submarines,” Bob said, “That’s number one, then we can start sorting through all these leaders that want us to run their countries,” Bob continued as he looked at the Storyteller.

None of them knew Bligh was in an Apache helicopter with his supporters flying towards Darwin.

Nor were they aware of the happenings inside the submarine that was now being steered by Fletcher Smith.

Along with the other forty-nine submarines, they were making their way northwards.

Fletcher, meanwhile, was startled and disappointed to look around and discover the Russian captain had a pistol pointed at his head.

“There has been a change of plans,” the unshaven Russian captain announced with the smell of vodka on his breath, “We want to ditch all those other submarines and go it alone,” he ordered, “They are a nuisance.”

Chapter Twelve

The Seat of Power

The very fast train pulled into the Central Hobart railway station after offloading a few hundred tourists under their glittering hotel complex on the outskirts of Hobart.

Bob was quickly driven to his office with a police escort.

Armed with a new walking stick, he strolled confidently into his office and sat down at his desk with the solar panel as its surface.

A camera was set up and a microphone was placed on his desk.

“Okay Mr. President, we’ve alerted all fifty submarines in the Timor Sea and they’re expecting you to appear any moment,” his main naval advisor informed him.

Small television screens dotted throughout all the cabins in the fifty Collins submarines flickered on revealing Bob Brown’s cheery but serious face.

“Good afternoon,” Bob said, “I am addressing all captains and crew members of the fifty Collins submarines now in the Timor Sea. The last few days have been some of the most eventful in Australia’s history,” he continued, glancing at his notes.

“I had been kidnapped, but this morning I escaped. I am now safely in my office in Hobart. The kidnappers have been captured and arrested.” He paused for a moment.

“However, when I was in captivity, and out of communication, Lieutenant Bligh, whom I only recently appointed Commander-in-Chief of the entire Collins fleet of one hundred and fifty submarines, took it upon himself to set sail with fifty subs to overrun England,” he said, pursing his lips.

“This is not how we do business around here, so as the President of Australia, I am formally commanding you to turn around and cruise back to Darwin Harbor, dock your submarines, and await further notice. This is an order,” he stated firmly.

“Lieutenant Bligh has been dismissed as Commander-in-Chief of the fleet and a new one will be appointed ...” he paused again, “... in due course. Thank you, have a good day.”

The many small TV screens went blank.

There was a mixture of disappointment, bewilderment and confusion amongst many of the submarine crew members, since they were looking forward to conquering England.

“Keep me updated on their progress,” Bob said to his senior naval advisor, “And can you give me a TV link-up with Adam right now?” he asked.

Immediately, Bandt, the Australian Prime Minister, appeared on another screen in Bob’s office.

“Hello again, Adam,” Bob said calmly, “I’ve ordered the fifty submarines back to Darwin Harbor.”

“A wise decision, Bob,” Adam replied nodding, “It’s an irony that this show of naval might by us has caused Britain and so many other countries to hand over rule to you, isn’t it?”

“Yes, I never expected this much power in my wildest dreams,” Bob answered, as he stroked his chin.

“Oh, and by the way,” Adam mentioned, almost as an afterthought, “The leaders of India, China, South America, Russia and the United States tweeted that they were more than happy to have you run their countries ...”

“How do you know this isn’t fake news?”

“No, it’s not. It was verified by Australia’s ambassador to Ecuador, Sir Julian Assange,” Adam assured.

“Hmm ... that’s about the whole world I now seem to control. A lot to manage,” he responded without flinching, “They certainly must like our greening policies here.”

“Well we have established ourselves as role models for other countries,” Adam replied, “How will you go about getting our policies implemented worldwide?” he asked.

“Well I’m too old, and it would be simply too impracticable, for me to swan around the world getting sworn in as leader of every country on earth, so can you arrange to have all the Australian Consulates to be sworn in on my behalf?” Bob requested matter-of-factly as Adam scribbled down notes.

“Too easy,” Adam replied.

“And then I’ll send out the list of twenty-five main reforms we want, you know, banning plastics bags, renewable initiatives, etcetera,” Bob said.

The Greens party has simplified their long-awaited reforms to twenty-five main ones, written out in plain English.

“The important thing is all of them have to be passed by the various governments, not just some of them, and enshrined in their constitutions,” Bob explained, “This should take less than a year, then once done I will stand down and return the power to the various governments,” Bob concluded, rubbing his hands together.

“I don’t really like the idea of being President of the World, Earth President, big titles, what-have-you, just as long as we get everything achieved.”

“Yes, I agree with you,” Adam replied, “I’ll draw up the list of reforms and have them ready to send out once everyone is sworn in,” he continued, “They’re on our website anyway.”

“I noticed no mention of North Korea,” Bob added.

“Oh, well that was another Breaking News event I forgot to mention to you,” Adam replied, “Apparently there was an unpopular uprising in Pyongyang sparked by so many countries wanting you as head, and their Dear Leader was overthrown and Korea is now united.”

“That’s wonderful, not before time,” Bob said optimistically. “Where is the Dear Leader now?”

“He’s gone into exile and is in hiding somewhere in China,” Bandt explained, “And his hairdresser has been executed.”

Bligh, meanwhile, was in the Apache helicopter and was landing on the helipad next to his office in Darwin.

He was soon in his office with the Sky News on and his secretary, overawed by everything, gave him a briefing.

“Basically you’ve been fired, I’m sorry to say,” she said sympathetically.

Bligh went into a rage.

“Get Brown on the phone!” he screamed at his secretary as she fled out of his office in tears. His phone beeped and he snatched it to his ear.

“I’ve got the President on the phone and he’s happy to talk to you,” she said hesitantly, “Connecting you now.”

“What the hell do you think you’re at sacking me, Brown?” Bligh yelled into the phone angrily, “You know full well if I hadn’t set off with fifty subs to overrun Britain you wouldn’t have ended up President of Earth, or whatever position you have now,” he blurted out.

“Yes, well that’s what I wanted to thank you about Jeremy”, Bob replied calmly.

It seemed to take the wind out of Bligh’s sails.

“Oh, I see,” he answered in a more conciliatory tone.

“Why aren’t you in your submarine with the other forty-nine anyway?” Bob inquired politely.

“Well we crashed into one of those mercenary merchant ships with Tarkine trunks on board and I arrested them,” Bligh boasted, “But Fletcher Smith organized a mutiny and stole my submarine.”

“Bummer,” Bob interjected.

“And my supporters and I were left on the merchant ship floating aimlessly ...” he continued with his lower lip quivering slightly.

“Why did you sign up a crew member called Fletcher in the first place, Bligh?” Bob quipped.

Bligh flew back into a rage.

“How the hell would I know, I just did!” he screamed, “And now Fletcher has the wood and my sub and is on his way to a secret meeting point somewhere to sell it! God, I detest mutinies.”

“So how did you get to your Darwin office?” Bob continued in a calm but curious tone.

“Oh, we discovered an Apache helicopter under the deck and one of my loyal crew members knew how to fly it, so here I am,” Bligh said, slowly losing his patience again, “So why can’t I have my job back?”

“Because you took the fifty subs without consulting me,” Bob replied getting annoyed himself.

“But you had been kidnapped!” Bligh yelled.

“Goodbye, Bligh,” Bob replied hanging up the phone.

Bligh then threw his phone on the floor and stamped on it cursing everyone. He then picked up his desk and heaved it through his large window sending broken glass everywhere.

The President strummed his fingers on his table. His senior naval advisor approached him.

“Mr. President, it appears all fifty submarines have turned around and are heading for Darwin, according to our radar, except for one,” he announced.

“Yes, I know. It has been hijacked by a certain Fletcher Smith, and it also contains stolen trunks from the Tarkine,” Bob explained, “And more than likely, David Collins is going after him with the submarine he is using without my go-ahead.”

Little did they realize that Fletcher had a gun at his head and was being told what to do, and where to go, by the crew of mercenaries and their captain, Vitaliy.

“It appears all the other subs are turning around,” Fletcher announced as his brow deepened.

“Well we’re not!” the Russian captain ordered as he waved his machine gun around, “Submerge now and switch on radio silence!”

With that, Fletcher obediently flicked some switches and looked at the radar showing forty-nine dots turning around and his dot moving forward.

“Will my crew and I still get a cut of the money from the logs?” Fletcher asked.

“I’ll think about it,” the Russian captain replied cursedly as he gulped down another vodka.

‘This will be a long journey,’ Fletcher thought to himself.

After a few hours, when their submarine had long ago separated from the rest of the fleet, the atmosphere was less charged and Fletcher and the Russian captain started chatting.

“Pretty amusing you mutinied and then I mutinied you,” Vitaliy said laughing.

“Hilarious,” Fletcher replied.

“I’ve read a lot of diaries and histories about the mutiny on the Bounty, so you’re a direct descendent of Fletcher Christian?”

“Yes I am,” Fletcher replied proudly.

“Why is your name Fletcher Smith then?” Vitaliy inquired.

“Long story, but in a nutshell I was finding it hard to get a job in the Australian navy, or any navy for that matter, not to mention bank managers being difficult,” Fletcher explained, “So I changed my name to Smith.”

“So your ancestors must have handed down a lot of stories?”

“Yes, we’re all mad keen on breadfruit from Tahiti and the West Indies,” Fletcher explained, warming to the topic, “And my ancestor was master’s mate to Lieutenant William Bligh.”

“Some mate ...” the captain replied.

“Well it was 1789, don’t forget, and Bligh meted out harsh punishments, criticism and unkind abuse to Fletcher in particular,” he continued in a tone of self-pity, “So enough was enough.”

Vitaliy snatched a map of the world and started comparing it with the route Fletcher was steering the submarine. He was an experienced sea farer.

“You’re going right, which means you’re heading towards the Pacific Ocean!” he said angrily.

“Well, doh, yes?” Fletcher replied defensively, “I wanted to drop in on Tahiti and Pitcairn Island, I have simply hundreds of relatives there,” Fletcher explained nostalgically.

The captain jumped to his feet and tapped his finger on the world map, foaming at the mouth.

“Don’t be stupid, you’re to turn left, we’re going via the Indian Ocean, Red Sea, then meeting our connection at the Mediterranean!” he demanded, as he put his finger on the trigger of his machine gun.

“Oh, alright then,” Fletcher conceded lamely, “But I have a wonderful extended family there, you would love them,” he replied, as he steered the huge submarine to the left.

Vitaliy sat down again and carefully folded up the map of the world and gulped down another vodka.

“What about you, do you have a nice family?” Fletcher ventured to ask like offering an olive branch.

“Oh me?” the Russian replied with a surprised look.

“Well my dear old mother confided in me one day, and said she was related to Nicholas II, Emperor of All Russia, second cousin, once removed, she told me.”

“Impressive,” Fletcher replied.

“There’s more,” he boasted, and began to sob, “She believed our family tree goes back to Ivan the Terrible in 1547, who was some sort of distant cousin. It’s all true,” he went on with a sly look into his glass of vodka.

“I’m sure,” Fletcher answered, “Far more impressive than my family tree,” he lamented, as he thought of his dear Hawaiian cousins and an opportunity missed to visit them again.

Chapter Thirteen

The United Nations

There had never been such a change to the United Nations since it was formed after World War II to promote international cooperation.

There were now over two hundred country members and the headquarters were still in Manhattan, New York, which was under twenty meters of snow.

The city was completely gridlocked after another climate catastrophe.

The representative for Australia, Richard Di Natale, adjusted his headphones as he listened to a speech by the Secretary-General, the Leader of the United Nations.

“And so, in conclusion, we can all be more optimistic about the recent changes, voted in today,” the UN leader announced warmly, as Richard nodded in approval.

“And we would like to thank the member representing Australia, Mr. Di Natale, for allowing all the UN member states in this deliberative assembly to maintain their seats here.”

Australia could have been churlish and demanded just one member sit in the UN assembly since essentially Australia was governing the world.

However, that was against the spirit of what everything the Greens and Australia stood for. And Richard himself had said this in an international press conference recently.

“It would have been very lonely for me if there was only one person sitting in the United Nations assembly, namely myself,” he said to the two-hundred-odd world media.

“The Greens want discussion and debate. After all, there are so many nationalities involved in this new world leadership,

and the last thing the Australian government wants is a spat in the International Court of Justice, the universal court for international law,” he announced.

People everywhere were still adjusting to the new order. “It is now 10 a.m. Green Time, and I call on Australia to give a briefing please,” the leader of the UN requested.

In the first vote by the assembly, ‘Greenwich Mean Time’ had been replaced by a simpler title, ‘Green Time,’ and so when the United Nations leader invited Di Natale to give a briefing to the Assembly, there was warm applause.

“Thank you,” Di Natale replied, as he lent forward to the microphone behind the small sign ‘Australia,’ placed in front of him.

“The raft of measures that the Greens government in Australia has put into law over the past decade has turned around a lot of issues that are affecting the world today,” he announced calmly as he adjusted his glasses.

“So even though it was surprising that our President, Bob Brown, is in the position he is in now, namely President of the World, we are delighted to help, and we would like to thank the United Nations for supporting us in such a positive way,” Di Natale continued.

“A clean energy powered future, ecological sustainability, peace and nonviolence are our central goals. Thank you.”

With that statement, a standing ovation followed. Nothing like this had happened before in the United Nations. The media was in a frenzy.

In an exclusive interview with CNN, Di Natale was more forthright.

CNN: “Probably one of your most contentious requests was the complete halting of the arms race everywhere?”

DI NATALE: “Yes, it will save most nations more money than at any time in their history.”

CNN: “But you didn’t ask for a scaling back of actual soldiers, why was that?”

DI NATALE: “Well we have exactly the same figures as you have. Virtually most countries can’t spare their military for fighting anyway. All soldiers around the world are constantly being deployed to help clean up the disasters in their own countries from the climate mayhem.”

CNN: “So you think it’s more common sense, or easier, to maintain that status quo?”

DI NATALE: “Definitely for the time being. Our advice would be to slowly transfer most armies into community projects. But this may take time.”

CNN: “But surely, after a year, when countries regain their own sovereignty, a lot of them will return to their old ways?”

DI NATALE: “Possibly. But don’t forget one of our platforms, that has to be enshrined in every countries’ constitution, is at least ten free press outlets per nation and, of course, the implementation of the Greens Manual for Manners.”

The Australian Prime Minister, Adam Bandt, had flown to Hobart to join Bob Brown in watching this historic event unfold in the United Nations Assembly on television.

The opening of a new Green Theme Park, just outside Hobart, had been postponed because of heavy flooding.

Roads had turned into rivers and cars had been swept down them like corks. As usual, climate change had caused havoc.

Eventually the weather cleared and the following day was set for the opening.

Disneyland had waded into the green theme park idea and had exploited it for all it was worth, and that was a lot.

“I’m looking forward to trying out the submarine ride,” Bandt suggested to Bob, as their official party made its way onto the podium, “I hear it’s the most popular one.”

Over two million tourists had already visited it in just three weeks, and the revenue was flowing into the Tasmania treasury on an unprecedented scale.

Speeches were made and the Australian President cut the green ribbon to open the amusement park in front of a big media contingent.

The official party was soon on the platform of the grand submarine ride. A large glass submarine, a replica in many ways of the Collins submarine, floated into position and the doors slid open.

Inside were eight seats across stretching back twenty-five rows seating about two hundred tourists.

The President and Prime Minister sat at the front alongside some of their staff and behind them sat the Storyteller and Speechwriter.

Erica had been careful not to push the envelope recently in her speechwriting.

Not only was she keen to keep her job, for obvious reasons, Bob now being President of the World being one of them, but she was apprehensive about her father, David Collins.

He had been out of radio contact for many days in his pursuit of Bligh.

Behind them, the glass submarine was packed with tourists. There was a minor jolt, and then it floated out from the platform and soon began to submerge.

The first scenery was dramatic since it was the Antarctic. Peering up, it looked like they were under a sheet of ice as penguins darted by in all directions.

In the real Collins submarine, the captain, David Collins, clicked some switches and turned off the radio silence.

“We’d better see where we are and what’s been happening in the real world,” he quipped to his second-in-command, “Let’s look at the global positioning system.”

But before they had a chance to look at that, they were surprised to see there were over twenty missed calls from the PM and President.

"Hmmm, I guess I had better return them," David said, as he tapped in the number of the President and waited.

In the glass submarine, one of Bob's staff handed the President his mobile phone.

"You've got an important call, guess who?"

"Hello David, how and where are you?" Bob asked calmly.

"Hello Mr. President, I'm fine," Collins replied as he glanced at the screen of his global positioning system, "And we're in the middle of the Mediterranean Sea, underwater, and there's no sign of Bligh."

"That's because he's back in his office in Darwin," Bob explained, "And without a job."

"Pardon?" Collins replied in surprise.

"Well, David, if you had bothered to return my phone calls you would have known by now that a crewman, Fletcher Smith, sparked a mutiny, and is now steering that sub," Bob explained patiently.

"At the time I wondered why Bligh would have someone called Fletcher in his boat," Collins surmised, "Hold on," he said as he looked at his radar, "There appears to be another Collins sub about ten kilometers in front of us. It appears to be stationary."

"Well that's probably him," Bob replied as he scratched his chin, "What do you plan to do?"

"Arrest him," Collins replied defiantly.

"But how can you? You have no authority," Bob said, "You stole your submarine ..."

"So you think I'm less untrustworthy than Fletcher?" Collins probed.

"Oh, alright then, David. Let me know when you get closer, good day," Bob said as he put away his mobile phone and looked at the scenery outside the glass submarine.

The theme park ride was absorbing, and it had left the amazing scenes of the Antarctic and was now in the Great Barrier Reef. The lights had gone off and the colorful coral lit up in the dark water. It looked spectacular.

“There’s nothing much we can do,” Bob said to Adam, “But wait.”

“I hope they don’t have some crazy shoot-out,” Adam cautioned, “Those subs are worth a fortune.”

Chapter Fourteen

The Deal to be Done

Fletcher gazed through the periscope, swiveling it slowly, from his submarine just below the surface of the water.

“Well? Can you see the ship?” Vitaliy asked angrily as he held his pistol and nursed a bad hangover.

“Nothing so far. What exactly am I looking for?” Fletcher replied patiently.

“It should be a merchant ship about the size of my one,” Vitaliy answered, “Big enough to carry the wood.”

“Don’t you think we might be too early?”

“What do you mean?” Vitaliy asked.

“Well, if you’d come here from Australia on your old merchant ship it would have taken weeks, but instead you got here on a modern Collins submarine. Surely much faster,” Collins suggested.

“Hmmp. You have a point.”

“Can’t you ring them and say you’re ahead of time?” Collins asked.

“Of course I can’t! We can’t give away our position here,” Vitaliy said, “There’s over thirty million dollars involved in this deal.”

“Well I think we should surface and just wait,” Collins suggested, “Give the crew some exercise out on deck, some fresh air.”

Vitaliy nodded in agreement and soon the submarine was floating on the Mediterranean Sea.

It was nearly morning. The sun came up and a lot of the crew did exercises on the deck. The water was flat. It seemed all was peace and quiet.

Abruptly, another Collins submarine surfaced alongside, sending waves everywhere as the seawater cascaded off it like a waterfall.

“Surrender!” Weapons were pointed and a voice came over the speakers, “You are under arrest!” David Collins announced firmly, “We represent the Australian government. Put down your arms right now!”

The various mercenaries and the Australian crew on top of Fletcher’s submarine raised their arms.

“I demand that Fletcher Smith comes up on deck with his arms on his head! You are under a citizen’s arrest!” Collins announced.

There was a long pause. The mercenaries exchanged glances and so did the Australian crew.

Then, emerging from the hatch, Vitaliy climbed out with his machine pointed at the head of Fletcher Smith.

“Don’t shoot!” Fletcher yelled, “I’m being held hostage!” They stood on the deck looking at the submarine alongside.

Nothing happened for a while.

The corresponding hatch opened and David Collins climbed out with a loud hailer.

They looked at each other.

“Don’t try anything clever,” Collins said loudly, “We have torpedoes aimed at you and can blow you out of the water. You are under arrest.”

“Oh no we’re not!” Vitaliy replied defiantly, “I will kill Fletcher and all your Australian crew.”

It was the classic standoff and it was tense. The two submarines alongside each other floated on the calm seas of the Mediterranean.

“Hold on,” Collins said, as he took out his mobile phone and tapped in some numbers, “I’ll just make a phone call.”

Bob Brown’s mobile phone starting ringing. He quickly answered it. He was seated behind his desk in his Hobart office. It was evening.

“Hello David? What’s happened?”

“We’re alongside the other submarine and are in a serious predicament,” Collins explained quickly, “We have our torpedoes aimed at the other sub, but Fletcher and his crew are being held hostage by Vitaliy and his mercenaries. It’s a standoff.”

“When will Vitaliy ever give up?” Bob said, as he glanced at the Storyteller, who was seated in the corner next to Erica.

Adam Bandt paced around. Bob put the phone’s loud speaker on so everyone in the office could listen in.

“Safety for our Australians is paramount,” Bob said urgently and then advised, “Keep them talking, that’s the number one rule in hostage situations.”

“Are they treating you well?” Collins asked Fletcher.

“Marvelously,” he yelled, “But they have a Tarkine log under deck and ...”

“Shut up!” Vitaliy screamed, putting his finger on the trigger, while he decided what to say next.

“Okay, we have a log ... give us twenty million dollars and you can have the log, your sub and your crew,” he bargained.

“Ask him where he thinks we can find that amount of money?” Bob responded, “Is there an ATM there?”

The Storyteller looked at Bob.

“Better than that, why not offer him twenty billion dollars for the submarine?” Bob suggested, as he looked at Adam.

They knew one big secret no one else did.

“Hey David, offer the mercenary twenty billion dollars for the sub,” Bob calmly suggested into his phone.

Collins was momentarily surprised. He raised his loud hailer and addressed the other submarine.

“I’m on the phone to our President, and he has offered to buy the submarine from you for twenty billion dollars! That’s what it is worth. We don’t care about the piece of wood.”

Vitaliy and his mercenaries looked at each other in disbelief. The Australians, concerned about their situation, looked bemused.

"In cash?" Vitaliy asked.

"Tell him, of course," Bob replied, "But tell him we'll need some time to arrange it."

"Yes, of course you can have the money in cash, but we'll need an hour or so," Collins announced in a friendly manner, "No tricks, we promise."

The mercenaries couldn't quite believe their good fortune. They had been hoping for twenty million dollars for the Tarkine log, but now they had been offered twenty billion dollars for the entire submarine.

Fletcher realized something was in the wind. He whispered to Vitaliy.

"The government doesn't want us harmed and these submarines are very important to our security," he urged, "Take the offer and be patient, for god's sake."

"Okay, okay!" Vitaliy replied defensively, "We'll take it. Everyone sit down then, and wait."

Erica scratched her head. "Call me stupid, but how can we raise twenty billion in an hour, Bob, pray tell?"

"Okay, keep this under your hat, it is top secret," he said nodding at Adam, "Only Adam and I know, and ASIO," he said quietly.

"When the previous government blundered into purchasing one hundred and fifty Collins subs, they thought it would cripple the Australian economy," he explained carefully, "So a secret clause was added by some bureaucrat writing the deal, it was top secret back then."

Erica lent forward in great interest, "I'm all ears ..."

"Well they had a money printing press installed in each Collins submarine," Adam continued to explain.

"You know, for upkeep, petrol, weapons, wages, etcetera," Bob interjected.

“Yes, so if the economy went pear-shaped, the fleet could survive by printing their own money,” Adam said with a strange expression, “You know how our civil service turns out apparatchiks with great ideas, well this was one of them.”

David Collins listened to their conversation with amazement.

“I didn’t know this. Where is the machine and I’ll go below deck and start printing the currency.”

“There’s a map on the wall in the subs kitchen, press on the exact location of the Canberra Treasury building and it will open,” Adam instructed.

Collins pointed his loud hailer at the other submarine, “Alright, I’m going below deck to arrange the money,” he said as he climbed into the hatch.

“Okay then,” Vitaliy replied, still not believing his luck.

Everyone on the deck sat down, waited, and enjoyed the morning sun over the Mediterranean.

Chapter Fifteen

The Humble Printing Press

David Collins rushed into the submarine's kitchen. The chef was asleep but soon jumped to his feet.

"Where is that map of Canberra?" Collins asked urgently, searching the small room.

"It's over there," the chef replied as he moved aside some boxes of pasta to reveal the map.

Collins squinted at the detailed map and located the exact position of the Treasury building, and tapped on it.

Magically, it opened and revealed a sophisticated printing machine with lots of buttons. He pressed 'on' and it all lit up.

"Okay, I've found it and turned it on," Collins said urgently into his mobile phone.

"Right," Bob replied optimistically, "I've got a senior technician with me from the Treasury, he'll navigate you through it," he said handing his mobile to a young man with gold-rimmed glasses.

"Monty here," he said, as he flicked through an instruction manual, "Locate the choice for currency. I guess you want to pay him in Rubles?"

"No. No, no ... not Euros either, do you think US dollars?" Bob asked looking at Adam.

"No, he'll wonder why we've got US dollars on board, conspiracy theories will spring to his mind, let's just print Australian dollars," Adam advised.

"Okay, Australian dollars it is," Collins replied as a few of his crew watched on closely, "Now what denomination? One-hundred-dollar bills?"

“Nope,” Bob said, “There wouldn’t be enough paper on board to print out twenty billion dollars.”

“And it would take all week,” Adam added.

“How about one-million-dollar notes? That shouldn’t take too long,” Bob suggested.

“But they don’t exist,” Collins replied.

Everyone went silent. Bob looked at the Storyteller sitting quietly in the corner of Bob’s Hobart office.

“Why not add four zeroes onto the hundred-dollar note design?” Marjory, the Storyteller, suggested.

“Yes, I can do that,” Collins said as he typed in extra zeroes, “But won’t he recognize the photo on the note as being the same as the hundred-dollar bill?”

Everyone went silent again. Then they all looked at Bob.

“How about a picture of Bob on it? He’s the President of Australia, and now the world,” Adam ventured to say.

“Can do. There is selection of pics here,” he said scanning through a number of passport photos of Bob, “Smiling or looking serious?”

“Smiling thanks,” Bob replied seriously.

“Done,” Collins replied, “But the other side, that needs to be changed.”

“Is there a rainforest landscape there?” Bob asked.

“Um ...” Collins scanned the selection of Australian landscapes, “Yep. Got a good one,” he said tapping on the selection. “All done, I’ll press ‘print’ then?”

“Yes, I give you the go-ahead,” Bob replied.

The machine hummed into action and one-million-dollar notes started spurting out like an overzealous ATM.

Collins grabbed a few and handed them to the crew and chef around him, “Here, buy yourself a yacht,” he quipped.

They examined them closely, held them up to the kitchen light, folded them, rubbed them, and then kissed them.

“Looks perfect to me,” Collins announced as hundreds of notes kept churning out.

They gathered them into piles of twenty, folded them over, and then put an elastic band around each bundle.

On the other submarine, Vitaliy paced up and down the deck impatiently and nervously with his machine gun at the ready.

Fletcher and some of the Australian crew sat down sunbaking in the late morning sun.

The mercenaries stood in a group enthusiastically comparing plans on how they would spend their mega-wealth. They were looking forward to becoming serious oligarchs.

An hour passed.

The hatch flung open on the other submarine alongside and a large yellow bag emerged followed by Collins. He stood on the deck, squinting into the sunlight, and lifted his loud hailer.

“Sorry we took so long,” he apologized, “Australian bank tellers can be annoyingly slow,” he announced, keeping his mobile phone on.

“Is it all there?” Vitaliy asked with a mixture of impatience and disbelief.

“Of course,” Collins replied, as he strolled down to the far end of his submarine deck, “Here, have it,” he called out as he flung the bag towards Vitaliy.

It splashed into the water between the two submarines. The eyes of the mercenaries widened in anger.

“Don’t worry,” Collins assured them, “It’s in a waterproof bag.”

Slowly the bag drifted over to the submarine and Vitaliy snatched it from the water. They quickly unzipped it and looked at the loot.

“Oh my god, look at the amount of it!” Vitaliy gasped as they examined the bundles. “I didn’t know you had one-million-dollar notes!” he exclaimed.

“But of course! This is the Australian economy!” Collins boasted. “Well? Count it.”

Immediately the mercenaries sat down in a circle on the deck and started counting the money.

Vitaliy put down his machine gun and started madly flicking through the bank notes, completely absorbed by this wonderful turn of events.

Meanwhile, the Australian crew members quietly walked backwards towards the hatch at the other end and climbed into it.

Fletcher suddenly kicked the machine gun into the sea and sprinted towards the hatch.

Vitaliy looked around in surprise and snapped out of his money-counting trance.

“Hey! My gun! What?” he shouted angrily, as he stood up and saw Fletcher climbing into the hatch. He started sprinting along the deck in a blind panic.

Collins waved at Fletcher as they simultaneously slammed shut their hatches and turned the circular wheel sealing the entrances completely.

Vitaliy frantically tried to open the hatch but it was locked. He kicked it. Then he stormed back to the others and they argued amongst each other.

There was muffled cheering from below deck as both Australian crews cheered.

“Deliver the lift raft!” Collins commanded.

A crewman pressed some buttons and a large hatch opened and out popped a big bundle of yellow plastic. It started to inflate like a balloon. Vitaliy and the mercenaries watched on in disbelief.

After less than a minute, there was a huge inflatable life raft floating between the two submarines. It drifted towards the other submarine.

“What a lovely scene,” Collins pondered, as he gazed into the viewfinder of the periscope, “Can we switch the vision through to the President’s office please?”

Everyone in Bob's office was still listening in through Collins' mobile phone.

They looked up and watched a special monitor that flickered on showing the mercenaries scrambling onto the large yellow life raft with Vitaliy clutching the bag full of money.

"Sorry to go you guys. You'll find plenty of food and water," Collins said to them through the loudspeakers, "Even some cold beers, enough to keep you going for weeks."

He turned to his second-in-command, "Let's get out of here."

With that order, the propellers on both submarines began to twirl and they started to slowly submerge creating small waves and a vacuum of bubbles.

Everyone in Bob's office watched with pride as the life raft rocked around and the vision was replaced by fish swimming around.

Finally, the water was calm and the mercenaries were adrift with their own thoughts.

One mercenary located the esky and opened it and took out some ice-cold cans of beer and handed them around. They all looked at each other, slightly relieved.

"Oh well, we still have twenty billion dollars," Vitaliy announced as he unzipped the yellow bag and continued counting the money.

"When a luxury yacht comes by, we can send up a flare," he continued, as he sipped on a beer, "Then we can buy it!"

They all laughed.

Chapter Sixteen

A Year Later

A year passed by like it was a day.

As promised, Bob Brown addressed the United Nations and handed back control of the two-hundred-odd countries to their own governments, dictatorships, or what have you.

He had strolled out after his speech with his walking stick and a thunderous standing ovation from all delegates and was interviewed outside, standing in the snow in Manhattan.

“What has been achieved, President Brown?” a reporter asked.

“Well in nearly all cases, our raft of laws have been passed by most countries and enshrined into their constitutions,” he replied enthusiastically, “And for the world it has been a real circuit changer. However, it might take decades for the laws to have a lasting effect,” he cautioned.

TIME magazine made Bob ‘Man of the Year’ and he was awarded the Nobel Prize for Useful Progress.

“Are you disappointed you’re not still President of the World?” the reporter asked.

“Not really. It’s been a lot of responsibility, and the workload for the Australian Greens and my government has been immense, but I’m still the President of Australia.”

With that, Bob was ushered into his limousine and driven to the John F. Kennedy International Airport. He boarded his jet, ‘Green World President One,’ and flew back to Hobart with his staff.

After a few days’ rest in his modest holiday house in the Tarkine forest, there was a knock on his door and standing there was the Storyteller and his Speechwriter.

“Rested?” Erica asked.

“Very. Are we all set? Let’s go,” Bob replied as they set off down one of the trails.

It had been arranged to have dinner with the ex-greenists in their tree house. They had been pardoned by the President for kidnapping him.

Instead, all four of them had been given four hundred hours of community service.

This was basically weeding the various Tarkine trails of introduced weeds and picking up litter left behind by the hundreds of thousands of tourists that used the tracks every day.

The Storyteller stopped for a moment to read a text she had just received.

“Oh,” she said in puzzlement.

“What’s wrong, Marjory?” Bob inquired, “You look like you’ve seen a ghost.”

“I just got a text from the Narrator,” the Storyteller said with a quiver in her voice.

“The omniscient Narrator?” the Speechwriter asked.

“The all-knowing Narrator?” Bob continued in a concerned tone, “What did he say?”

“The text asks, ‘Is it a good idea to go into the forest this evening?’” the Storyteller replied.

“Why shouldn’t you?” Bob answered, “The weather is perfect and I’ve got my security around.”

The Storyteller shrugged her shoulders and they continued walking, quite often passing hundreds of tourists at a time.

A fog-like mist descended around them as they strolled deeper into Tarkine rainforest.

Emerging out of the mist, and approaching them, was a large group of Arabic tourists. There was about twenty of them.

The men were in shorts and shirts and the women in hijabs, a mix of Shayla, khimar and chador. There were even a few in niqabs and burkas.

“Hello,” Bob said holding out his hand. Everyone stopped.

“Are you the President of the World?” one man said as they shook hands.

“Was,” Bob replied, “I’m only the President of Australia now,” he said correcting them.

“You’ve done so much for our country,” one woman said as she pulled her headscarf off her head, revealing long black hair and a pleasant face, “We are a tour group from Saudi Arabia,” she explained.

“What benefits have you found in the past year?” Bob asked them all.

“Well as you can see, my hijab is now green and not black,” one lady quickly answered.

“Ah, of course,” Bob said looking more closely at their flowing robes, “I didn’t notice. The dark green looks so good.”

There was more small-talk and selfies were enthusiastically taken and they went happily on their way.

After another few hundred meters, with Bob, Erica and the Storyteller absorbed in their conversation about their recent meeting with Saudi Arabians, Bob stopped.

“Can you hear that?” Bob asked as he looked around, “I can hear someone groaning,” he said curiously.

The three exchanged glances and listened carefully.

“There it is again,” Bob said pointing into the bush, “I think it’s coming from in there.”

“Yes, yes,” Erica agreed with him, “I can hear it too. Do we have permission to leave the track?”

“Of course. Let’s go in there,” Bob said, since the fines for leaving any trail were very big, not least the community service hours.

They began pushing aside tree fern fronds and vines and stepped over moss covered logs with a mysterious mist overlay as the groans became louder.

They came across a tourist lying on the ground clutching his foot. They ran up to him.

“Are you alright?” Erica asked, as she reached the person first.

“Oh thank god!” he said in relief, “I’ve been here for three days. Water, water, can I have water?”

“Yes, of course!” Erica said, kneeling down and handing him her bottle, “It’s Pure Franklin spring water.”

The man gulped down the whole bottle.

Erica was immediately on her mobile phone, “HQ, can we have medics here please, we’ve found an injured tourist?” Erica ordered, as she texted through their precise location.

“What happened to you?” Bob inquired sympathetically.

“Well I was walking by myself,” he answered softly in a French accent, “When a Tasmanian Tiger jumped out of the thick bush!” he dramatically described.

“It started growling and suddenly lunged at me and bit my leg,” he explained painfully, as he parted his trousers to show a bloody wound.

“That’s bad,” Bob said screwing up his face. “How did you end up here then?”

“Well it continued to growl at me and so I jumped into the forest to find a stick to beat it off!” he said, building the drama, “But do you think you can find a stick in here?”

“I’m sure it would have been hard,” the Storyteller sympathized.

“Well eventually I did, and I whacked it a few times and it disappeared into the bushes,” he concluded, “And then I passed out.”

The distant wailing of an ambulance siren could be heard echoing through the forest.

“Ah, help is on its way,” Bob said looking around, “Then what happened, tell me?”

“Well I regained my consciousness and used most of my water to clean my wound and drank the rest. Then I yelled out, ‘Help, Help’, but no one helped me for three days until you all arrived.”

They all looked at each other in an eerie silence, only broken by the approaching siren.

Then they slowly began to recognize each other.

Pardon me, but are you Monsieur Adelard Voclain, the translator?" Bob asked.

Adelard looked up guiltily at Bob. His lips began to quiver.

"Yes, I am," he confided, "And you're President Bob Brown?"

"Yes, I am," Bob replied as he gently patted him on the back, but then turned to Erica.

"Go to the track and meet the ambulance and bring them here," he ordered.

Erica leaped into the bush and was soon at the track waving down the ambulance as it skidded to a standstill. Medics jumped out with a stretcher.

Ten years previously, Adelard Voclain became the most famous public servant in Australia. He was the person who did the translation for the Collins submarine deal.

"I'm so sorry I made that typographical error in my French translation that the previous government signed off on," he said, almost begging forgiveness. "I typed an extra 0 on the 15. It meant Australia had to buy one hundred and fifty Collins submarines," he confessed, with a tear rolling down his cheek.

"Oh, no, no, no! Don't be silly," Bob protested, "Without that error, the previous governments would not have been swept out of office in such an unprecedented landslide," Bob continued, "You caused the Greens to win office! You saved Australia!" Bob concluded, shaking his hand.

At that moment, medics burst through the thick tree ferns clutching a stretcher.

They began administering first aid on Adelard's wound and carefully lifted him onto the stretcher.

"You'll be okay," the medic said looking more closely, "But it looks like gangrene has set in."

“Who would ever think such an infection could occur here?” Bob pondered aloud.

They followed the medics as they carried Voclain on the stretcher to the jeep-like ambulance.

Soon the ambulance was screeching away along a track towards the Tarkine Animal and Human hospital.

The President, the Storyteller and the Speechwriter continued their walk deep into the rainforest. The mist cleared and sunshine broke through the canopy. They stopped to look at a beautiful Pixie’s Parasol, Mycena interrupta.

“Speaking of submarines,” Erica said wistfully, “It was very kind of you to pardon my father, even though he lost his job as Commander-in-Chief of the one-hundred-and-fifty-odd submarine fleet. He did, after all, redeem himself by capturing that rogue, Fletcher Smith.”

“Well your father did well,” Bob replied in appreciation, “The way he sealed that deal with Vitaliy was amazing.”

Not only had David Collins been pardoned by the President, but he was enjoying himself doing a worldwide lecture tour promoting his best-selling novel.

Even Captain Jeremy Bligh had landed on his feet by being appointed Ambassador to France.

And Fletcher Smith was under ‘island arrest,’ to see out his years on the islands of Tahiti and Pitcairn with his enormous extended family.

“Well my best decision was to scrap the position of Commander-in-Chief completely,” Bob said.

Half the fleet was safely docked in Darwin Harbor, and the rest scattered around the Australian coastline with a few chasing Japanese whaling ships in the Antarctic Ocean.

As the late afternoon sun readied to set, Erica looked down at the Google Maps on her mobile phone and pointed ahead.

“I think our destination is about here,” she announced confidently.

They noticed a tall tree, and looking up they could see a tree house nestled in the canopy.

“Well this is a giveaway,” Bob said as he noticed a large sign at the base of the tree reading, ‘VOTE 1, EXGREENISTS.’

Next to it was an intercom system. Bob pressed a button and spoke into it.

“Bob Brown and friends here for dinner.”

“Greetings,” came the familiar voice of Jack over the tiny speaker, “I’ll send down the lift.”

The ex-greenists had been pardoned by The President and became famous. So much so that they formed a new party and decided to stand for office in the local Tarkine council elections on a green ticket.

Chapter Seventeen

The Dinner Party

A large green box landed on the ground and the doors opened like a lift. The three of them stepped in and pressed the button, 'Penthouse.' It slowly ascended the very old tall tree into the canopy.

The Storytellers mobile beeped and she looked at it.

"Hmm, another text from Mr. Omniscient Narrator," Marjory lamented.

"Are you sure this is a good idea?' he asks this time," the Storyteller muttered.

She avoided eye contact with Bob as he scratched his head.

The lift stopped and the doors parted and standing there was Jack and Jessica smiling.

"Welcome to the official party!" Jack said warmly as they all embraced.

Bob looked around in awe at the now spacious and luxurious tree house.

"Wow! You've really spruced up your tree house Jack. It really is like a penthouse."

"Yeah, well I sold the rights to our kidnapping yarn to Hollywood and the money has poured in," he said shaking his green dreadlocks around, "But I like it up here, so we rarely use our mansions in Hobart."

"I see," Bob replied looking around more carefully, "Where are the others, just Jessica and yourself here?" he probed delicately.

"Oh yeah, that!" Jack answered as he shrugged his shoulders, "We had a split in the ex-greenists party, as you do, so they formed their own 'splinter party,'" he said motioning inverted commas with his fingers.

“Anyway, two additional guests just arrived for dinner,” Jack added, as he stared into Bob’s eyes, as if they were windows into the universe.

Melinda and Bill Gates walked into the room.

“Ah, good, you got my invitation?” Bob said proudly, “Great to see you both,” he continued as they shook hands.

“Well we were on our annual visit to the safari park and were happy to fly down here for a stroll through your Tarkine,” Bill said.

Bob introduced them to the Storyteller and his Speechwriter, who were seriously impressed.

“My laptop keeps freezing,” Erica said, as she handed it to Bill, “It’s a Windows.”

Bob stroked his forehead in despair.

“That’s okay,” Bill said, as he took it and sat down at the table and opened it.

“Bill always gets requests like this,” Melinda said, as she assisted Bill, “What’s your password?”

“Oh, I would prefer not to divulge it,” Erica said matter-of-factly, “I have a lot of top-secret speeches on it.”

“How can I fix it then?” Bill replied with a quizzical expression.

“Okay, cover your eyes while I type in my password,” Erica said as Bill and Melinda obediently put their hands over their eyes and the Speechwriter typed in the word, ‘Green words.’ “There, done.”

Her laptop flickered on.

“I can see the problem immediately,” Bill said, glancing at his wife. He pulled out his handkerchief and started wiping the screen.

“A lot of this Tipp-Ex on your screen has dribbled onto your keyboard,” Bill patiently explained. “There, fixed,” he continued, as he chipped away the dried white Tipp-Ex from between the keyboard keys.

“Bill, you must get tired of people pestering you to fix their computers?” Bob pondered as he scowled at his Speechwriter.

“Well it’s no different to you solving the problems of the world,” Bill replied, as Melinda nodded in agreement.

“Thank you so much, Mr. Gates,” Erica gushed unashamedly. Soon all seven were seated together having dinner.

They had a lot to catch up on, especially about the previous year, where Bob had successfully navigated his way through the World presidency.

Table conversation invariably turned to the problem of poachers operating in the sprawling safari park in Western Australia.

“We find there are not only poachers now,” Bill explained to everyone, “But this new phenomenon of do-gooders hunting the poachers.

“Yes, you briefed me on this,” Bob recalled, “It is quite remarkable that these people actually form groups and hunt down the poachers and try and kill them.”

“Humans. Tell us about it,” Melinda replied with a sigh.

“The problem being, as much as we appreciate their enthusiasm, they are still committing murder and, if caught, end up in jail,” Bill lamented.

“And these Samaritans don’t even use guns because they are banned,” Bob replied wistfully, “Instead they use bows and arrows, and they stalk the poachers, kill them, and then ...”

The sound of a helicopter interrupted Bob’s gruesome tale.

“That’s unusual,” he said glancing at the Storyteller, “What’s a chopper doing so close at this time of night?”

Erica stepped over to the window and looked out into the darkness of a Tarkine night. She pulled out her binoculars.

“Hmm. That’s an Apache,” she announced.

“Mercenaries!” Bob cursed. “Erica, ring the military!” he ordered as they all peered out various windows.

“They’ll take twenty minutes to get here,” Erica replied, as she waited for the local military base to answer, “They’ll

be out of here with a trunk in ten minutes,” she continued, calmly tapping in an estimated location.

Bob grabbed his walking stick and stepped over to the lift and jabbed on the button.

“Well I’m going after them!” he announced angrily, as the lift doors parted.

“Count us in,” Bill said enthusiastically, as they all crowded into the lift.

“And so are we!” the Storyteller and the Speechwriter answered joining them.

Jack and Jessica looked at each other in a confused state.

“We have to do the washing up,” Jack pleaded.

Bob pressed on the lift button with his walking stick. As the lift doors closed, he stared at Jack.

“Thanks for the dinner and good luck with your council election,” Bob said between clenched teeth and the lift ascended.

“I’ve alerted my security circle,” Bill announced having pressed a button on his wrist watch, “They’ll be swarming around in minutes.”

The lift finally arrived at the base of the tall old tree. The doors opened and they were surprised to be confronted by about twenty armed security people in rainforest camouflage.

“Ah, you’re here already,” Bill announced.

“Our helicopters will be here shortly,” one security agent assured Bill.

“Good, we think it’s poachers after an old growth tree again, so let’s go,” Bill instructed his bodyguards as they joined the five of them and strode into the dark of the Tarkine Forest.

All they could hear was the sound of the helicopter.

“I think it’s about hundred meters over there,” Bob said breathlessly as they followed a narrow walking track clutching small torches to guide their way.

From the Apache helicopter, hovering above, four mercenaries shimmied down ropes and yanked on their chainsaws, which fired them into action making a deafening noise.

It was a well-rehearsed show of stealth.

They approached the huge old growth tree trunk and two of them began sawing at the base from both sides.

Three more helicopters, gleaming in the darkness, emerged from over the horizon.

“Ah, that looks like our air security arriving,” Melinda announced as she glanced at Bill, “And there will be many more on motorbikes you’ll soon find.”

As they all neared the crime scene, a bandicoot suddenly stood frozen in the headlights of their torches on the path in front of them.

“A bandicoot!” Bob exclaimed in surprise, “Marjory, can you photograph it quickly? It’s a *Perameles gunnii*, I think.”

Marjory, the Storyteller, fumbled to turn on her mobile phone camera to take a picture.

The bandicoot darted into the forest and Marjory went after it.

Bob, Erica and the Gates hurriedly continued along the track surrounded by their security contingent of twenty heavily-armed people virtually invisible in rainforest camouflage.

The noise of the helicopters high above the canopy and the chainsaws was deafening.

Finally, they arrived near the tree that was being cut down.

A balaclava-headed man was standing nearby with his stopwatch. He was surprised to have a spotlight turned on him.

“Hello Vitaliy,” came the exhausted voice of Bob Brown, “Stop what you are doing!” he ordered.

Vitaliy swung around and pointed his torch back onto Bob’s face. He immediately realized it was the President of Australia.

“Not this time,” Vitaliy said, reaching for his pistol. Erica could do nothing.

The sound of military and police sirens could be heard in the distance and three helicopters surrounded the black apache in the nighttime sky.

The chainsaws continued unabated.

Suddenly there was a loud cracking sound. The huge three-hundred-year-old myrtle began to lean. Everyone looked up.

Bob used the distraction to strike with his walking stick.

Swinging it with accuracy, he whacked the hand of Vitaliy, breaking it, and sending his pistol flying into the nearby ferns.

Vitaliy glared at Bob in an angry and hurtful way.

But the huge tree was falling. The mercenaries and Vitaliy fled into the dark forest with some of Gates security in pursuit.

The tree toppled over with an enormous crash that echoed around the Tarkine.

The only other sound was a faint human call, "Ah ..."

Bob glanced at Erica and the Gates then they all looked around frantically.

"Where is the Storyteller?" Bob asked urgently.

Immediately they followed the path of the tall fallen tree. Beaming their torches in all directions, they spotted a bright light under some of the branches.

Bob was drawn towards it. He parted some branches and leaves and there was the Storyteller.

She was lying there, alone, skewered by a sharp broken branch that had pierced her heart.

They leant down to comfort her. She looked at Bob kindly, and tried to smile, but her eyes closed.

Her mobile phone revealed a picture of the bandicoot.

The Storyteller had passed away.

So, therefore, the book ended.

The End

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The author



Michael Nicholson was born in 1954 in Melbourne, Australia. He attended Scotch College, where he pursued an interest in writing as the Editor of the school's magazine, Satura. Since then, he has explored various careers including those in publishing, television, art, animation

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